# Fairness at a Price: Support for Complex Benefit Systems

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**Abstract.** Claiming welfare benefits involves substantial transaction costs. Simplifying benefit systems is on the policy agenda in many countries, but progress has been slow. I study whether public support can explain this, using a spectator experiment and a survey experiment in the Netherlands. Most spectators accept substantial effort costs on claimants for a modest improvement in targeting accuracy, but their support is sensitive to the size of these costs and falls when it fails to reach everyone it is meant for. In the survey experiment, information about the costs of complexity shifts respondents' beliefs but does not, on average, raise support for simplification. This average hides heterogeneity: respondents who have not received benefits become more supportive of a simpler system, whereas recipients do not, even though they update their beliefs at least as much and do not have more accurate priors at baseline. Across both experiments, support for simplification is thus sensitive to its costs among those who have nothing to lose from it. Building widespread support among the rest may therefore require resolving uncertainty about considerations people find salient when evaluating the reforms, such as how reform would affect their own entitlements.

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# 1. Introduction

> *We are convinced that these ancient laws are scrupulously administered; nevertheless it is an extremely painful thing to be ruled by laws that one does not know.*
>
> — Franz Kafka, *The Problem of Our Laws* (1920)

Claiming and keeping welfare benefits often involves substantial transaction costs: claimants must fill in forms, document their circumstances, report changes, and understand the rules that determine what they are entitled to. In the United Kingdom, for example, the claim form for the Personal Independence Payment, a disability benefit, runs to 50 pages. In the Netherlands, an official evaluation of the allowance system found that only 43% of recipients know what changes in their situation they need to report (Kok et al. 2022). These costs reduce take-up of benefits (Kleven and Kopczuk 2011; Castell et al. 2025), and lead eligible recipients to lose their benefits when they fail to meet procedural requirements (Homonoff and Somerville 2021). The costs of complexity became nationally salient in the Netherlands during the childcare allowance scandal (*toeslagenaffaire*), over which the government resigned in 2021.[1]

Simplifying benefit systems is on the policy agenda in many countries, but progress has been slow. In France, consolidating social benefits into a single social allowance, first proposed in 2017 and revived by each of the last three prime ministers, has yet to be introduced (Jacquot 2026). In the Netherlands, simplification has been widely discussed since the childcare allowance scandal: in 2024 and 2025, the Dutch parliament unanimously adopted motions calling for a fundamental reform of the allowance system (Tweede Kamer der Staten-Generaal 2024; Tweede Kamer der Staten-Generaal 2025). In the latest elections, two thirds of the party programmes included proposals to simplify the system.[2] Yet beyond small adjustments, comprehensive reform has not been undertaken (van Dijk 2026).

If complexity is so costly, why do complex benefit systems persist? I study whether a lack of public support, which would make reform politically infeasible, can explain why complex systems persist, a question on which there is little evidence. One reason people may oppose simplification is that they accept the transaction costs that complexity

[1] It was revealed that thousands of parents had been accused of fraud and required to repay their allowances, although most of them had made only small administrative errors, often because they did not know the rules (Kok et al. 2022). A parliamentary inquiry called this "unprecedented injustice" (Parlementaire ondervragingscommissie Kinderopvangtoeslag 2020).

[2] Author's reading of the 2025 election programmes, accessed via NOS (https://nos.nl/collectie/13999-verkiezingsprogramma-s, accessed 25.02.2026).

imposes on claimants as the price of fairness: complex rules, requirements, and procedures target benefits more accurately (Kleven and Kopczuk 2011; Nichols and Zeckhauser 1982).[3] Another is that people may underestimate these costs, which are largely invisible to those who do not claim benefits (Herd and Moynihan 2019). I study these two explanations using two experiments. In a spectator experiment, I examine whether support for a complex system is sensitive to the effort costs it imposes on claimants, and whether this support falls when the system fails to reach everyone it is meant for, even though it retains its targeting advantage. In a survey experiment in the Netherlands, I provide respondents with official statistics on costs of complexity of the Dutch welfare system and measure whether correcting their beliefs changes their support for simplification reforms.

In the experiment, impartial spectators choose between two budget-neutral compensation systems for a group of 12 workers whose earnings were reduced by a random shock. The Complex system compensates workers affected by the shock, but only after they complete a verification form that takes extra, unpaid time. The Simple system pays automatically based on the worker's colour, a tag correlated with the shock (Akerlof 1978), but it targets compensation less accurately. I vary two features of the Complex system: (i) the length of the form, mirroring the transaction costs of complex welfare systems, and (ii) whether it excludes some workers it was meant to compensate, mirroring the failure of real systems to reach some of the people entitled to support. Total compensation and the Complex system's targeting advantage over the Simple system are kept constant in all treatments. A simple conceptual framework predicts that a utilitarian spectator becomes more supportive of the Complex system when the form is shorter, but is unaffected by its failure to reach everyone, since its targeting advantage, and thus the welfare difference between the two systems, is unchanged.

Most spectators choose the Complex system even when workers have to 56 minutes of unpaid time in total on the form so that one more payment is accurately targeted. I show that support for the Complex system responds to both changes: it rises by 19 percentage points when the form takes two minutes instead of seven, and falls by 15 percentage points when the system fails to reach a single affected worker (both $p < 0.01$). The two effects are of comparable size: leaving a single deserving worker uncompensated costs the Complex system about as much support as it gains from reducing its recipients' unpaid effort by forty minutes in total. Spectators thus appear to reward a system that compensates

[3]Theories of optimal transfer design understand complexity as a way of sorting the needy from the rest: it either sharpens the signal of need (Kleven and Kopczuk 2011) or deters the less needy from claiming (Nichols and Zeckhauser 1982). In fact, there is evidence that transaction costs can even increase public support for the programmes that impose them, because they signal that recipients are deserving and that the programmes are legitimate (Keiser and Miller 2020).

every deserving worker, and a single exclusion error removes this premium. The drop in support once the Complex system does not target perfectly is concentrated among left-wing spectators.

When evaluating actual reforms, people may weigh the costs of complexity against many other considerations, from budgetary costs and labour supply responses to their own interests and trust in government (Kuziemko et al. 2015; Stantcheva 2026). I examine this in a survey experiment with 2,728 respondents in the Netherlands, where the simplification of the benefit system is high on the political agenda. I elicit beliefs about three salient costs of complexity in the Dutch system: non-take-up, difficulty of the allowances' rules, and the risk of having to pay back benefits at the end of the year. Respondents in the treatment group are provided with the correct figures from official statistics. I then measure respondents' support for simplification reforms.

I find that respondents underestimate the costs of complexity and that information about these costs shifts their beliefs, but on average does not raise support for simplification. This average, however, hides heterogeneity, most notably by whether respondents have received benefits. While both recipients and non-recipients update their beliefs, only non-recipients become more supportive of a general simplification of the system. The difference is not explained by prior beliefs, differences in baseline support for simplification policies, attention, or experimenter demand, and it survives allowing the treatment effect to vary with all other respondent characteristics. Recipients' open-ended justifications point to a personal stake in the system: they more often argue that a reform could cut their benefits and reason from their own situation.

My results highlight two explanations for why complex benefit systems remain in place. Spectators accept a substantial burden on claimants for a modest improvement in targeting accuracy, suggesting that even small decreases in accuracy may make reforms unpopular. Across both experiments, the support for complexity of people who judge the trade-off impartially is sensitive to its costs. This is not the case for those with personal stakes in the system, i.e., Dutch benefit recipients. This suggests that for those who incur these costs, other considerations, such as uncertainty about how a reform would affect their entitlements, may be more salient. Reducing this uncertainty may therefore matter as much for the feasibility of reform as making the costs of complexity visible to those outside of the benefits system.

This paper contributes to three literatures. First, it adds to the experimental literature on fairness views (Konow 2000; Cappelen et al. 2013; Durante, Putterman, and Van der Weele 2014; Almås, Cappelen, and Tungodden 2020; Cappelen, Cappelen, and Tungodden 2023a; Andre 2025). Previous experiments have priced fairness as lost efficiency (Durante,

Putterman, and Van der Weele 2014; Almås, Cappelen, and Tungodden 2020) or as the decider's own forgone payoff (Piraino and Ryan 2024). I introduce a price of a different kind: an unpaid effort cost incurred by the beneficiaries themselves, mirroring the transaction costs in real welfare states. Methodologically, I extend the spectator design, in which spectators usually allocate earnings between individuals, to the choice of a rule for a group: like policymakers, the spectators in my experiment choose between systems that differ both in the errors they make and in the effort costs they impose on recipients. This allows me to show that fairness judgements of allocation rules depend not only on individual outcomes but also on properties of the rule as a whole, such as whether it reaches everyone it is meant for.

Second, the survey experiment adds to the literature on information experiments about redistribution (Cruces, Perez-Truglia, and Tetaz 2013; Kuziemko et al. 2015; Karadja, Mollerstrom, and Seim 2017; Alesina, Stantcheva, and Teso 2018; Fehr, Mollerstrom, and Perez-Truglia 2022). These studies typically shift beliefs that influence how much people want to redistribute. I instead shift beliefs about how redistribution is delivered, i.e., beliefs about the costs that the complexity of the welfare system imposes on claimants. It also adds to survey experiments on administrative burden in political science (Keiser and Miller 2020; Baekgaard, Moynihan, and Thomsen 2021; Halling and Van de Walle 2026). The closest, Keiser and Miller (2020), shows that more administrative burden increases support for policies because respondents see it as a signal that recipients are deserving and the programme legitimate. I inform respondents not about the burden itself, but about its consequences for claimants. Among respondents who have never received benefits, who have no direct stake in the system, this information raises support for a simpler system.

Finally, the paper adds to the public economics literature on how to target transfers when need is unobserved (Akerlof 1978; Nichols and Zeckhauser 1982; Diamond and Sheshinski 1995). Conceptually closest is Kleven and Kopczuk (2011), who model complexity as a by-product of screening: it improves the accuracy of targeting but imposes transaction costs on claimants. Empirical work measures how these costs affect take-up and targeting (Bhargava and Manoli 2015; Alatas et al. 2016; Finkelstein and Notowidigdo 2019), and the literature on administrative burden documents them in citizens' interactions with the state (Burden et al. 2012; Moynihan, Herd, and Harvey 2015; Christensen et al. 2020). I provide experimental evidence on how the public weighs targeting accuracy against the transaction costs and show that the public accepts substantial transaction costs for accurate targeting, but that this support is fragile when the system fails to reach everyone.

The rest of the paper is organised as follows. Section 2 describes the design of the spectator experiment. Section 3 presents a conceptual framework and derives the hypotheses. Section 4 reports the results of the spectator experiment and examines potential mechanisms. Section 5 presents the survey experiment, including its institutional context, design, and results. Section 6 concludes.

## 2. Experimental Design

I develop an experimental set-up that allows me to study how individuals trade off the transaction costs of a compensation system against the accuracy with which it reaches its intended recipients. It builds on the spectator design used in experimental studies of fairness (Konow 2000; Cappelen et al. 2013; Almås, Cappelen, and Tungodden 2020), in which an impartial spectator makes a decision that affects other people's earnings. This set-up differs from the standard spectator design in three ways. First, spectators choose a system that determines an allocation for a group of twelve workers, rather than deciding on an allocation for a pair. Second, the experimental manipulation concerns the properties of this system, rather than the source of the underlying inequality. Third, the spectator's choice determines not only what workers earn but also what they must do to receive it.

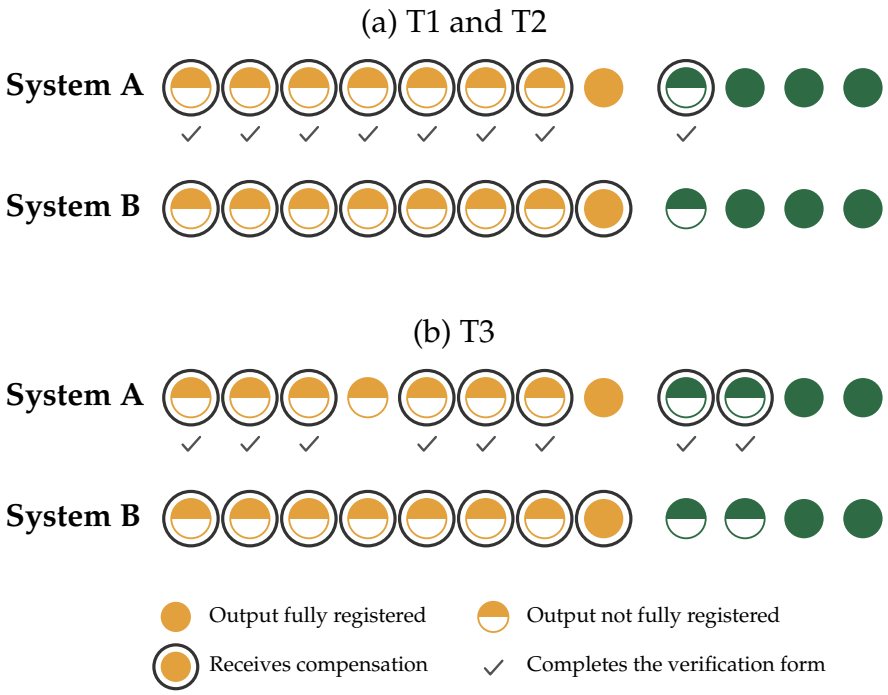
The experiment involves two types of participants. Workers complete a paid real-effort task, and for some of them part of their output is, at random, not registered, so they earn less. Spectators, who are the focus of the analysis, decide how a compensation is allocated among a group of twelve workers. They choose between two systems. Both systems have the same budget and compensate the same number of workers by the same amount; they differ only in who receives the compensation and what workers must do to receive it. Under the Complex system,[4] compensation is accurately targeted at the workers whose output was not fully registered, but they must first complete a verification form that takes extra, unpaid time. Under the Simple system, compensation is paid automatically and at no transaction cost, but is targeted less accurately, since it is conditioned on the worker's colour (a tag correlated with lost output).[5] I vary two features of this trade-off across treatments: (i) the length of the verification form, that is, the cost of complexity (Kleven and Kopczuk 2011), and (ii) the targeting accuracy of the Complex system. The primary

[4] I use the word "complex" in the sense of Kleven and Kopczuk (2011): complexity is the rigour of the screening a scheme uses to establish eligibility, which provides a better signal of who is truly entitled but imposes transaction costs on claimants. In the online experiment, this takes the form of a single requirement, the verification form, which imposes high or low transaction costs on the workers, depending on the treatment.

[5] In the experiment, spectators see the two systems under neutral labels, System A (Complex) and System B (Simple).

outcome of interest is the spectators' choice between the two systems. Figure 1 shows, for the group of twelve workers each spectator decides for, who is compensated under each system, both in the treatments where the Complex system targets perfectly (T1 and T2) and in the treatment where it does not (T3); Section 2.2 describes the treatments in detail.

**Figure 1.** The two compensation systems, by treatment




*Note:* Each circle is one of the twelve workers a spectator decides for. In every treatment both systems compensate eight of the twelve workers and pay each of them the same amount. The verification form in System A takes seven minutes in T1 and T3 and two minutes in T2.

### 2.1. Workers

*Worker characteristics.* Each worker is randomly assigned a colour, Yellow or Green. They are also assigned to have their output fully registered or not. All workers work for the full fifteen minutes of the working session, but for some of them only the tasks completed in the first eight minutes count towards their performance bonus. They are therefore paid for fewer tasks than they actually complete, and earn less than otherwise identical workers. Colour is an informative but imperfect proxy for output not being fully registered: in the group each spectator decides for, seven of the eight Yellow workers have output that is not fully registered, against one or two of the four Green workers, depending on the treatment (Section 2.2).

*Workers' information.* At the start of the experiment, workers are told that part of their completed output might not be registered, as the result of a random process outside their

control. They are not told how likely that is, from which point in the session it might happen, whether it differs by colour, or which colour they have been assigned. This means that workers cannot condition their performance on whether their output is fully registered. Workers are also told that a decision by another participant may affect their final payment, but not which systems are possible, how that decision is made, or how the compensation is determined.

*Tasks and earnings.* In the first part of the experiment, workers complete a series of real-effort tasks for fifteen minutes. These tasks include counting how many times a given digit appears in a string of numbers, counting how many times a given letter appears in a sequence of letters, and encoding word sequences into numbers. They receive a fixed participation fee and a performance bonus that increases in the number of tasks they complete correctly. On top of that, depending on the spectator's choice, they may receive compensation. The compensation is defined to spectators (but not to workers) as the difference between the average performance bonus of workers whose output is fully registered and that of workers whose output is not, so it equalises the two groups' bonuses in expectation. Workers were paid a fixed fee of £3.20 and a median performance bonus of £0.55 (£0.98 for workers whose output was fully registered, £0.50 for workers whose output was not). The compensation was equal to £0.47. Spectators were not told this amount, because it depends on workers' performance and was determined only after spectators had made their choices.[6]

The second part of the workers' experiment depends on the decision of the spectator. If the spectator chooses the Simple system, workers finish the experiment after the fifteen-minute working session. If, on the other hand, the spectator chooses the Complex system, those workers whose output was not fully registered complete a verification form. The form mirrors the verification requirements of real benefit programmes that ask claimants to report their circumstances, background, or activity, often in great detail.

Depending on the treatment, the form takes two or seven minutes to fill in.[7] The form contains more items than can be completed in the allocated time, and is timed; workers

[6]Not stating an amount also avoids inviting spectators to compare the minutes on the form with the small amounts paid in an online study, which would make their choice depend on how they convert time into money.

[7]Workers' responses in the form do not affect their payment; only completion matters, and every worker who completes the study completes the form. Tying payment to the *content* of the form would make the design more complicated; spectators would then have to form beliefs about workers' error rates, and the perfect targeting in some of the treatments (see Section 2.2) could no longer be guaranteed. This is an interesting avenue for future research. Workers are told that a rule of the study requires them to keep working on the form for its full allocated time. They appear to comply: the median last click on the form was at 97% of the allocated time in both form lengths.

cannot submit it before the allocated time ends and are moved on automatically once it ends. It contains several types of questions, about (i) administrative details of their working session (e.g., date, start and end times, minutes worked, device, operating system); (ii) estimates of their own performance in different types of tasks and the strategy they used; (iii) the environment in which they completed the tasks (e.g., location, noise, lighting); and (iv) their Prolific activity and habits. Workers who fill in the seven-minute form complete the same items and are then asked for a more granular account of their performance. They are shown non-copiable tables listing words or letters, some of which appeared in their tasks, each paired with an arbitrary six-character code, and must report the codes of the items they believe they worked on. They are also asked to provide further details of their working session and to evaluate the tasks they worked on.

### 2.2. Treatments and Compensation Systems

Spectators are randomly assigned to one of three between-subject treatments, T1, T2 and T3, summarised in Table 1. Each spectator is shown a group of twelve workers: eight assigned to Yellow and four to Green. Figure 1 shows this group, whose composition is fixed within each treatment, and who is compensated under each system. In T1 and T2, seven of the eight Yellow workers and one of the four Green workers have output that is not fully registered. In T3, seven of the eight Yellow and two of the four Green workers have output that is not fully registered.

*The Complex system (System A).* Compensation is conditioned on whether output was fully registered, and receiving it requires workers to complete the verification form, which imposes a transaction cost on them. Workers whose output was not fully registered complete the form and receive the compensation; workers whose output was fully registered do not. In T1 and T2 the system targets perfectly: all eight workers whose output was not fully registered complete the form and are compensated. In T3 the form is unavailable to one of the seven Yellow workers whose output was not fully registered, who therefore receives no compensation.

*The Simple system (System B).* Compensation is conditioned on colour. Every Yellow worker receives the compensation automatically, and Green workers receive nothing; no worker completes a form or spends any additional time. The system therefore pays one worker whose output was fully registered and misses the Green worker (T1 and T2) or workers (T3) whose output was not. It is the experimental analogue of a scheme that conditions on an observable tag correlated with need (Akerlof 1978).

In every treatment both systems compensate exactly eight of the twelve workers, and each compensated worker receives the same amount, so total expenditure is identical under

both systems and across all treatments. In T1 and T2, the Complex system compensates every worker whose output was not fully registered; to receive the compensation, these workers must complete a verification form that takes seven minutes (T1) or two minutes (T2). In T3, the form again takes seven minutes, but it is unavailable to one Yellow worker whose output was not fully registered. This worker does not fill in the form and therefore does not receive the compensation, so the Complex system misses one such worker. Spectators are told that this is outside the worker's control: the worker neither causes nor can prevent it. Comparing T1 with T2 isolates the effect of the transaction cost, holding the resulting distribution fixed. Comparing T1 with T3 captures the effect of the Complex system losing its perfect targeting, holding fixed the form length, total expenditure, and the Complex system's advantage over the Simple system. To keep the budget fixed, the T3 group has one more Green worker whose output was not fully registered than the T1 group.[8] Together, these changes mean that both systems miss one more worker whose output was not fully registered than in T1: the Complex system goes from zero to one, and the Simple system from one to two, so the Complex system retains its relative advantage of compensating one more such worker than the Simple system (see Section 3).

**Table 1.** Treatments

| | Targeting of the Complex system | Form length | Isolates | *N* |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| T1 (reference) | perfect | 7 min | — | 313 |
| T2 | perfect | 2 min | transaction cost (vs. T1) | 320 |
| T3 | one worker excluded | 7 min | imperfect targeting (vs. T1) | 295 |

*Notes:* Treatments are between subjects. In every treatment both systems compensate eight of the twelve workers, each by the same amount, so total expenditure is identical across systems and treatments. In T3 the verification form is unavailable to one worker whose output was not fully registered, who is therefore not compensated; the group composition adjusts to preserve budget neutrality, and both systems miss one more worker whose output was not fully registered than in T1. The column "Isolates" reports the effect each treatment isolates relative to T1. *N* is the number of spectators in the main sample (928 in total), after excluding respondents who failed the attention checks or were flagged by Prolific's bot check.

### 2.3. Spectators

The spectators' experiment starts with a consent form, a pledge not to use AI tools, a pledge to read the instructions carefully, and a standard attention check. Next, spectators read the instructions. They learn that the workers are recruited to complete the task *individually* for

[8]Without this change, excluding one worker whose output was not fully registered would leave the Complex system compensating only seven workers, while the Simple system would still compensate eight, so the two systems would no longer have the same budget.

payment, and they learn about the other properties of the worker set-up: that workers are assigned a colour, are paid for the tasks they complete, and that, for some of them, part of the output is not registered and therefore does not count towards their performance bonus.[9] Spectators then learn that they will choose how the compensation is allocated among the workers, and that there is more than one way to do so.

They are then shown the twelve workers they will decide for on a figure that visualises the group's composition (see the full instructions in Appendix B.1). This is followed by a description of the two systems: who is paid, who is not, and what is required. For each system a figure shows which workers receive the compensation and which complete the form, and a table summarises the time each type of worker spends and what they are paid. Spectators are reminded that the compensation amount is identical under both systems and that each compensates eight of the twelve workers. They then answer a comprehension quiz of eight true/false items, with a gated option to re-read the instructions beforehand; a wrong answer triggers a short clarification of the item concerned.

After the quiz, spectators choose which of the two systems to implement for the twelve workers they were shown. The allocation implied by each system is displayed alongside the choice, together with a reminder that both systems pay the same amount to each compensated worker and compensate eight of the twelve. Spectators are told that their decision is anonymous and is not observed by other participants. They are also told that workers know that their final payment may depend on a decision made by a participant in a related study, but not how that decision is made or which systems are possible. Because workers are unaware of the systems, spectators have no reason to believe their choice can meet or disappoint workers' expectations. The choice is probabilistically incentivised: for one in thirty spectators, the chosen system is implemented for a group of twelve workers, which determines who is compensated and whether workers must fill in the form. To reduce the risk that spectators infer that I want a particular type of worker to be compensated, I tell them that whether they are selected does not depend on which system they choose and that there are no right or wrong answers.

After the choice, spectators are asked questions about their perceptions of the systems and their choice. They are first asked an open-ended question about the reasons for their choice. Next, they are asked closed-ended questions about the effort (the transaction cost)

[9]The instructions emphasise the individual nature of the task, avoid the word *group* throughout, and inform spectators that workers do not know what others receive. This reduces the risk that spectators judge the systems by imagining group dynamics among workers. For example, if workers were to work together on a group task, spectators might believe it is fair to grant compensation to everyone in one group (i.e., Yellow or Green) in order to minimise feelings of envy or regret, which is something the experiment does not aim to capture.

and fairness of the systems: how much more effort the Complex system requires of workers than the Simple system, from 0 (no extra effort) to 10 (far more effort), and which system's distribution of the compensation is fairer, judged only on who is and is not compensated, from 0 (Complex much fairer) to 10 (Simple much fairer), with 5 labelled neither. In T3, where a worker whose output was not fully registered can miss out either because of the system's rule (Simple) or because the form is unavailable (Complex), spectators are also asked whether they find one reason more unfair than the other, from 0 (missing out under the Complex system is much more unfair) to 10 (missing out under the Simple system is much more unfair).

In the last part of the study, spectators answer a short battery of questions about their trust in and perceptions of the competence of government departments and institutions; their view of the trade-off between targeting and ease of claiming as it arises in real benefit systems, on a bipolar item from 0 ("benefits should be universal and easier to claim") to 10 ("benefits should be targeted, even if harder to claim"); their support for two simplification policies (an automatic income-based payment in the style of a negative income tax, and a universal basic income), fairness attitudes, generalised trust, political attitudes, and demographics.

### 2.4. Design Choices

*Budget neutrality.* Because both systems compensate eight of the twelve workers by the same amount, a spectator's choice cannot express a view about how much compensation should be paid, only about the form it should take: an accurate but costly system or a simpler but less accurate one. This is an advantage of the experimental setting. In reality, simplification reforms may also change how generous or costly the system is (e.g., some variants of a universal basic income; Goderis and Vlekke (2023)), so that support for reform can mix views about administrative design with views about the size of the welfare state.

*Deciding for a group.* The spectator chooses for a group of twelve workers rather than for the pair of the standard spectator design. This mirrors real welfare states, where transaction costs are borne by many claimants: the experiment tests whether spectators would impose these costs on many workers in exchange for a small increase in distributional fairness.

*Fairness of the two systems.* To create a sharp tension between distributional fairness and transaction costs, the Complex system is designed to be clearly fairer under the main fairness views. For egalitarians, it produces a more equal distribution of final earnings;

for meritocrats, it pays for work done but not registered;[10] and for luck egalitarians, it corrects brute luck unrelated to effort or ability (Cappelen et al. 2013; Mollerstrom, Reme, and Sørensen 2015). Finally, a libertarian could regard the low pay as the just outcome of a voluntary exchange, since workers agreed to work knowing their output might not be registered. Even so, of the two systems, the Complex one better honours the entitlement to the fruits of one's labour (Nozick 1974), since it directs compensation to the workers who produced the output that was not registered.

*Exclusion in T3.* The exclusion of a worker whose output was not fully registered is framed neutrally, as the form being unavailable to that worker. The aim is to make targeting explicitly imperfect without narrowing the exclusion to one specific reason, such as errors of the screening technology or non-take-up, so that the results speak to exclusion in general rather than to one of its causes. The framing does not appear to make this exclusion seem particularly unfair: asked after their choice which reason for missing out is more unfair, spectators in T3 on average rate missing out because the form is unavailable as slightly less unfair than missing out because of one's colour (Section 4). Because the exclusion is outside the worker's control, however, the results may not extend to exclusion that people attribute to claimants' own decisions rather than to the system, such as non-take-up if it is seen as the claimant's choice.

*Fixed take-up.* Studying non-take-up would require letting workers decide whether to apply for the compensation. Allowing this in only one treatment, or with different probabilities across treatments, would give spectators an additional signal about the value of the compensation or the severity of the transaction costs, and would do so differently across the cost treatments. I therefore hold take-up fixed and require every worker whose output was not fully registered to complete the form. Endogenising take-up, so that it responds to the transaction cost and to the value of the compensation as in Kleven and Kopczuk (2011), is a natural avenue for future research.

*What the design abstracts from.* The setting deliberately removes several features of real benefit systems. Which workers deserve compensation is clear under the main fairness views, and the verification form is accurate, so that no worker can obtain compensation in the Complex system without being entitled to it; concerns about fraud, need, and contested deservingness therefore play no role. The cost of complexity is also one-dimensional: the time and effort of completing a form, rather than stigma, uncertainty about one's entitle-

[10] All workers complete the full fifteen-minute session. Had some workers instead been prevented from working part-way through, their claim to compensation would be less clear, since people reward effort even when the opportunity to exert it is outside one's control (Bhattacharya and Mollerstrom 2025; Andre 2025).

ments, or the risk of having to repay benefits (Moffitt 1983; Kleven and Kopczuk 2011). Removing these features allows me to examine whether people give up distributional fairness when it imposes costs on claimants. In real welfare states, however, other considerations, such as fraud and the deservingness of claimants, may also matter, and people may evaluate different costs of complexity differently. This is one reason to complement the spectator experiment with a survey experiment on the Dutch welfare state (Section 5).

### 2.5. Experimental Procedures

Spectators were recruited on Prolific, restricted to adult UK nationals whose first language was English, who resided in the UK, and who completed the study on a desktop, laptop, or tablet. 990 spectators completed the study and were approved on Prolific. As per the pre-registration, I exclude respondents who failed the attention checks or were flagged by Prolific's bot check, which leaves a final sample of 928. The pre-registered robustness sample additionally excludes the bottom 5% of time spent within each treatment and respondents with more than one incorrect answer on the comprehension quiz (709 spectators). Spectators were paid a fixed fee of £3.50 and a bonus of £0.25 if they answered all comprehension questions correctly. The median completion time was 14.4 minutes.

Spectator data were collected first. One in thirty of the 990 spectators who completed the study was then drawn at random, so that 33 spectators had their choice implemented. For each drawn spectator, I recorded the treatment they faced and the system they selected, and the system was implemented for a group of twelve workers with the composition the spectator was shown, so that 33 groups, or 396 workers, were run in total.[11] The worker sessions were run in five separate Prolific studies, one per distinct (treatment, chosen system) worker experience. All workers completed the fifteen-minute working session; workers matched to a spectator who chose the Complex system, and whose own output was not fully registered, additionally completed the verification form, which lasted seven or two minutes according to the spectator's treatment (except, in T3, the single worker for whom the form was unavailable).[12]

Workers were recruited from the UK and the US. Their pay is described in Section 2.1.

[11] Of the 33 groups, 27 went through the Complex system (13 in T1, 12 in T2, and 2 in T3) and 6 through the Simple system (3 in T1 or T2, and 3 in T3).

[12] In practice, 8 of the 349 workers who consented to the Complex-system worker studies (2.3%) left the study when they reached the form, without answering any of its questions. As with other participants who dropped out at any point of the study, they were not included in the implemented groups, so every worker in an implemented group whose output was not fully registered completed the form.

## 3. Conceptual Framework and Hypotheses

This section presents a simple framework to derive hypotheses about how support for the Complex system changes across treatments. The main implication is that a utilitarian spectator should be unaffected by the exclusion in T3. Appendix C gives the full derivations.

### 3.1. A Utilitarian Benchmark

Each worker $i$ earns $y_i$ in the study: $y_L$ if their output was not fully registered and $y_H > y_L$ if it was. A worker's consumption is $c_i = y_i + b_i$, where $b_i = b$ if the worker is compensated and $b_i = 0$ otherwise. All workers exert effort $e_T$ on the tasks, and workers who fill in the verification form exert additional effort $e_V$. Workers value consumption and dislike effort:

$$U_i = u(c_i) - v(e_i), \qquad u' > 0,\ u'' < 0,\ v' > 0. \tag{1}$$

I assume that the spectator is utilitarian and chooses the system that maximises social welfare over the group of twelve workers, defined as the sum of their utilities:[13]

$$W = \sum_{i=1}^{12} U_i. \tag{2}$$

The *targeting gain* $N$ is the gain in social welfare from paying the compensation to a worker whose output was not fully registered rather than to one whose output was, and the *burden* $B^t$ is the loss in utility of a worker who fills in the form in treatment $t$, in which the form requires effort $e_V^t$:

$$N \equiv \big[u(y_L + b) - u(y_L)\big] - \big[u(y_H + b) - u(y_H)\big] > 0, \quad B^t \equiv v(e_T + e_V^t) - v(e_T) > 0. \tag{3}$$

$N$ is positive because $u$ is concave: the compensation raises utility more for a worker who earns less.

In T1 and T2, both systems compensate the seven Yellow workers whose output was not fully registered, and differ only in who receives the eighth payment (Figure 1, panel (a)): the Simple system pays it to the Yellow worker whose output was fully registered, the Complex system to the Green worker whose output was not. Redirecting this payment is the Complex system's targeting advantage, worth $N$. In exchange, all eight workers

[13] In $W$, $u$, $v$ and $b$ describe the spectator's beliefs about how workers value earnings and effort and about the size of the compensation. Spectators are not told the amounts in pounds, but they know how long the form takes and that the compensation closes the average earnings gap, $y_L + b = y_H$. Spectators may differ in these beliefs; I suppress the spectator index.

it compensates fill in the form, at a total burden of $8B^t$. The difference in social welfare between the Simple and the Complex system is therefore $\Delta^t \equiv W^S - W^C = 8B^t - N$, and the spectator chooses the Complex system if $\Delta^t < 0$, that is, if the targeting gain outweighs the burden on the eight workers who fill in the form.

A shorter form lowers the burden, $B^{T2} < B^{T1}$, and leaves the targeting gain unchanged, so the Complex system becomes more attractive.

**Prediction 1 (Transaction cost)** *Any spectator who chooses the Complex system in T1 would also choose it in T2, so the share choosing the Complex system is weakly higher in T2.*

In T3, the form is unavailable to one Yellow worker whose output was not fully registered, and, to keep the budget fixed, a second Green worker's output is not fully registered (Figure 1, panel (b)). Both systems therefore leave one more such worker uncompensated than in T1, and eight workers still fill in the form under the Complex system. Its advantage over the Simple system is unchanged: it still redirects exactly one payment from a worker whose output was fully registered to one whose output was not, at the cost of eight forms. Hence $\Delta^{T3} = 8B^{T1} - N = \Delta^{T1}$. Although the Complex system no longer reaches every worker it is meant to compensate, a utilitarian spectator makes exactly the same choice as in T1.

**Prediction 2 (Exclusion)** *Every spectator makes the same choice in T1 and T3, so the share choosing the Complex system is the same.*

For a utilitarian spectator, the exclusion of a single worker does not matter, because it takes nothing away from the Complex system's advantage over the Simple system, and thus support for Complex should be the same in T1 and T3. The prediction also holds for any generalised-utilitarian welfare function, $\sum_i \varphi(U_i)$ with $\varphi$ increasing.[14] I pre-registered this benchmark (H2, with Prediction 1 as H1) together with the two-sided alternative that support for the Complex system changes in T3.

### 3.2. Alternative Hypotheses

Below, I discuss three cases in which support for the Complex system may nonetheless change in T3; these seem the most plausible.

[14] Compared with T1, the T3 group has one more Green worker whose output was not fully registered. Under the Simple system, this worker is not compensated. Under the Complex system, this worker fills in the form and is compensated, but the Yellow worker to whom the form is unavailable is not. Under both systems, the group therefore ends up with one fewer worker whose output was fully registered and one more worker whose output was not fully registered and who is left uncompensated, while all other workers are as in T1. Social welfare under both systems changes by the same amount, whatever $\varphi$ is, so the choice does not change.

*The first exclusion weighs more.* A utilitarian spectator's evaluation is separable across workers. A spectator may instead value a system for compensating *every* worker whose output was not fully registered, as under a premium on perfect targeting (Isaac and Spangenberg 2021), or be less concerned with each additional exclusion. In T3, the exclusion is the Complex system's first, which ends its perfect targeting, but the Simple system's second, so support for the Complex system falls. A spectator may also judge each system by its worst-off worker, as under a Rawlsian criterion, so that the Complex system loses its advantage as soon as it leaves one such worker uncompensated: in T3 both systems leave such a worker uncompensated and tie on their worst-off worker, and support falls as long as some spectators who become indifferent choose the Simple system.[15]

*The reason for exclusion matters.* A utilitarian spectator also judges the systems only by the welfare they give workers (welfarism), not by why a worker goes without compensation. Under the Simple system, workers miss out because of their colour; under the Complex system in T3, because the form is unavailable to them. A spectator who finds exclusion through an unavailable form more (less) unfair than exclusion by colour supports the Complex system less (more) in T3.

*Design-related explanations.* Finally, support for the Complex system could fall if spectators perceive T3 differently from what the design intends. In T3, unlike in T1, both systems miss some workers whose output was not fully registered, so the Complex system's fairness advantage is less obvious; spectators may then choose more noisily or miss the advantage, both of which lower support for the Complex system. The burden of the form may also become more salient once the fairness comparison is less clear-cut. Learning that the form is unavailable to one worker may also change what spectators believe about the form in ways the design does not intend.

## 4. Results

### 4.1. Main Results

To examine whether support for the Complex system responds to its transaction costs and to imperfect targeting, Figure 2 shows the share of spectators who implemented the Complex system (System A) in each treatment. A majority implements it in every treatment: 68% in T1, where the form takes seven minutes, almost half the working session,

[15] This requires that the compensation outweighs the burden of the form, $B^{T1} < u(y_L + b) - u(y_L)$; otherwise the workers who complete the form are the worst-off under the Complex system in both treatments, and a Rawlsian spectator chooses the Simple system in T1 and T3 alike. If ties are broken by comparing the next worst-off workers (leximin), the Complex system still wins in T3. Appendix D discusses rank-dependent welfare functions, which lie between the utilitarian and the Rawlsian case.

and the Complex system targets perfectly; 87% in T2, where the form takes two minutes; and 54% in T3, where the Complex system no longer reaches every worker whose output was not fully registered. Although spectators are not told the amount of the compensation (Section 2.1), they are told that it equals the difference in average earnings between workers whose output is fully registered and those whose output is not, and that the latter are paid only for the tasks completed in the first eight of the fifteen minutes, and so lose the pay for the tasks completed in the last seven. In T1, choosing the Complex system means that eight workers spend 56 unpaid minutes in total on the form so that a payment worth about 7 minutes of work goes to a worker whose output was not fully registered instead of one whose output was. The time cost of the Complex system is thus 8 times the value of the payment it redirects, when both are measured in minutes of work.[16] To test whether these differences are statistically significant, Table 2 reports the corresponding regressions of system choice on treatment indicators; the reference category is T1 (perfect targeting, high transaction costs). The regression in Column 2 controls for respondents' characteristics including age, gender, education, income, and whether the respondent has ever received benefits.

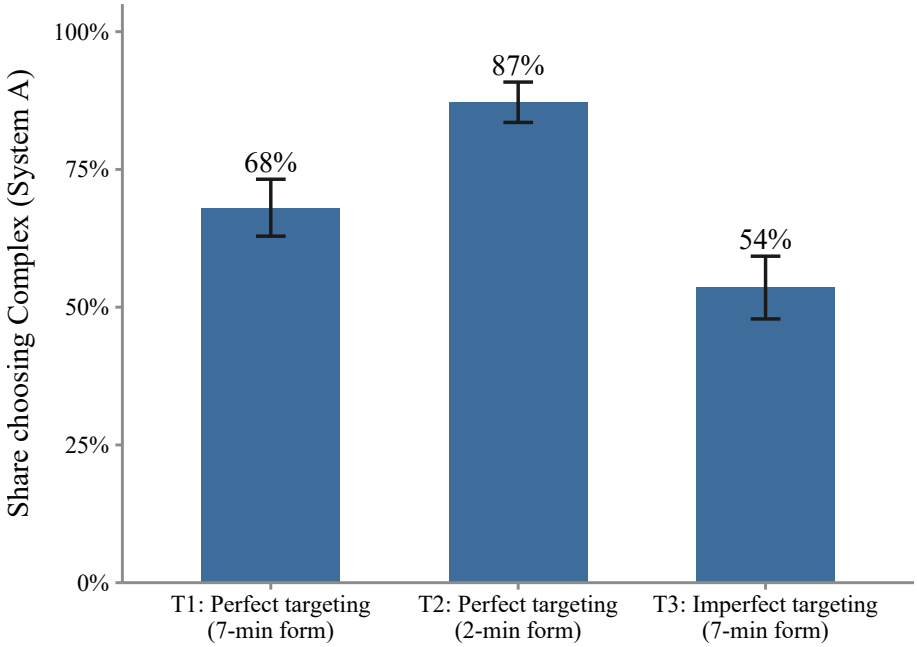
Both costs and accuracy of targeting significantly influence support for the Complex system. Lowering the transaction costs (T2) raises the share choosing Complex by 19 percentage points ($p < 0.01$), in line with Prediction 1. Introducing imperfect targeting (T3) lowers support by 15 percentage points ($p < 0.01$), contrary to Prediction 2. Support for the Complex system thus falls once it makes a single targeting error, even though its advantage over the Simple system, measured in workers reached, is unchanged. The two effects are of comparable size, and the difference between their absolute sizes is not statistically significant ($p = 0.46$): the loss of support from a single targeting error is comparable to the gain from shortening the form by five minutes.

### 4.2. Mechanisms

To understand what drives spectators' choices, I elicited a set of perceptions and open-ended justifications after spectators made their decision. These measures were elicited after the choice so as not to influence it, but as a result they may partly reflect the choice already made rather than the considerations that produced it, and are therefore only suggestive. As a manipulation check, perceived effort, a proxy for the perceived transaction cost of the Complex system, is significantly lower in T2 than in T1 (Appendix Table A1, Columns

[16] This assumes that spectators regard (i) a minute on the form as costly as a minute of work, as in the framework, and (ii) the marginal cost of effort as constant. If spectators instead see the cost of effort as convex, the form, which comes after the fifteen-minute session, weighs more, and the ratio understates the burden they accept.

**Figure 2.** Spectator's choice of compensation scheme, by treatment




*Notes:* Notes: The figure reports the share of spectators who chose to implement the Complex system (System A) for the group of workers. Error bars indicate the 95% confidence interval. (N = 928)

(1)–(2)). This is consistent with the lower burden of the Complex system driving its higher support in T2: controlling for perceived effort reduces the T2 effect from 19 to 6 percentage points (Appendix Table A2). To understand why support falls in T3, I examine the three cases discussed in Section 3.2 in turn.

*The reason for exclusion matters* One possibility is that spectators object to *how* the Complex system excludes a worker, by denying access to the form, more than to how the Simple system excludes, by conditioning on an imperfect proxy. This is a departure from welfarism (Section 3.2), because the way spectators evaluate the systems then depends on more than workers' welfare: if spectators find exclusion through an unavailable form more unfair than exclusion by colour, support for the Complex system falls in T3. To test this, in T3 I elicited which form of exclusion spectators find more unfair, setting aside how many workers each affects. The distribution of responses is shown in Appendix Figure A1.[17] If anything, spectators lean the other way, which by the logic of Section 3 would raise rather than lower support for the Complex system in T3: the mean response of 5.41 lies

[17]Responses were elicited on a scale from 0 ("missing out under System A is much more unfair") to 10 ("missing out under System B is much more unfair").

**Table 2.** Choice of the Complex system

| | Chose Complex (System A) | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| T2 (low cost) | $0.191^{***}$ | $0.190^{***}$ |
| | (0.032) | (0.032) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | $-0.145^{***}$ | $-0.145^{***}$ |
| | (0.039) | (0.039) |
| Constant | $0.681^{***}$ | $0.710^{***}$ |
| | (0.026) | (0.063) |
| Controls | | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.088 | 0.088 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable equals 1 if the spectator chose to implement the Complex system (System A) and 0 if they chose the Simple system (System B). The independent variables are indicators for T2 (perfect targeting, low transaction cost) and T3 (imperfect targeting, high transaction cost); T1 (perfect targeting, high transaction cost) is the omitted category. Column (2) adds controls: age (in years), an indicator for being female, an indicator for having a Bachelor's degree or higher, an indicator for a yearly household income of at least £45,000, and an indicator for having ever received benefits. The sample (main sample) consists of all spectators who completed the study and passed both attention checks, excluding submissions returned on Prolific or flagged as likely bots. The results replicate in the pre-registered robustness sample, which additionally excludes respondents in the bottom 5% of time spent on the study within their treatment group and those with more than one incorrect answer on the comprehension questions (see Table A8). Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

significantly above the neutral midpoint of 5 ($t = 3.01$, $p = 0.003$),[18] and more spectators regard exclusion under the Simple system as more unfair (36.9%) than under the Complex system (21.7%), with 41.4% seeing the two as equally unfair. Moreover, spectators who regard missing out under the Complex system as more unfair are not significantly less likely to choose it than those who regard the two reasons as equally unfair (39% against 43%; two-sample test of proportions, $\chi^2(1) = 0.18$, $p = 0.68$), and support among the latter is well below its level in T1. Procedural concerns are therefore unlikely to be the main explanation for the fall in support in T3.

*Design-related explanations* The transaction costs are held fixed by design between T1 and T3. However, if spectators do not perceive them as equal, this could decrease the support for Complex in T3. Perceived effort required to receive compensation increases by

[18]This holds on the robustness sample (Section 2.5): the mean response is 5.42, significantly above the neutral midpoint of 5 ($t = 2.60$, $p = 0.010$, $N = 208$).

0.31 points on the 0–10 scale in T3 relative to T1 in the main sample (marginally significant) and by 0.57 points in the robustness sample ($p < 0.01$; Appendix Tables A1 and A9). This increase could reflect a general disapproval of the imperfect-targeting condition or, since the question is asked after the choice, post-choice rationalisation. The spectators were aware of the length of the form; in every treatment, almost all correctly answered a comprehension question about it (T1: 95.8%; T2: 93.1%; T3: 92.5%). Perceived effort is strongly related to the choice in every treatment, but controlling for it reduces the T3 effect only from 14.5 to 12.9 percentage points (Appendix Table A2). It is thus unlikely that the difference in perceived effort explains the lower support in T3.

An alternative explanation is that the choice is more difficult in T3: unlike in T1, both systems miss some workers whose output was not fully registered, so the Complex system's fairness advantage is less obvious. Spectators who struggle with the setting may then choose more noisily or miss the advantage, so the fall in support should be concentrated among them. I find no evidence of this (Table 3). The T3 effect does not differ by education or comprehension, the two available proxies for how difficult spectators find the task. Among spectators who answered every comprehension question correctly, support still falls by 15.6 percentage points in T3 relative to T1 ($p < 0.01$; 14.5 percentage points among all spectators, Table 2), and the T3 results are the same in the robustness sample (Appendix Table A15).

Finally, when neither system compensates every worker whose output was not fully registered, the fairness comparison may become less salient, shifting spectators' attention to the burden of the form. To examine this, I use spectators' open-ended justifications of their choice, coded with a large language model for whether each response mentions (i) the fairness of the resulting distribution and (ii) the verification burden.[19] Appendix Figures A2 and A3 report the share of spectators raising each consideration, by treatment and by the system they chose. The responses provide no support for this explanation. The form is not mentioned more often in T3 than in T1, if anything slightly less (45% against 50%), even though more spectators choose the Simple system in T3. Spectators who turn away from the Complex system in T3 thus do not appear to do so because the burden of the form has become more salient. The comparisons within each choice point the same way: among spectators who choose the Simple system, those in T3 mention fairness more often (66% against 58%) and the form less often (70% against 77%) than those in T1, and among those who choose the Complex system, the form is mentioned less often in T3 (23%) than

[19] Responses were coded with GPT-5.6 via the GABRIEL package (Asirvatham, Mokski, and Shleifer 2026). A factor is coded whenever it is raised as a consideration, so a mention need not be the decisive reason for the choice: a response such as "I disliked the form, but I went with what is fair" is coded as raising both fairness and the verification burden. Appendix X reports the prompts.

in T1 (38%), despite identical verification costs. These comparisons are, however, only suggestive, since they condition on a choice that the treatment affects.

**Table 3.** Choice of the Complex system: heterogeneity

| | Chose Complex (System A) | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Interaction with moderator | | | Split sample | |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) |
| T2 (low cost) | 0.244*** | 0.211*** | 0.265*** | 0.130*** | 0.267*** |
| | (0.058) | (0.038) | (0.050) | (0.041) | (0.051) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | −0.151** | −0.156*** | −0.052 | −0.224*** | −0.046 |
| | (0.070) | (0.052) | (0.057) | (0.055) | (0.058) |
| Moderator | 0.039 | −0.051 | 0.144*** | | |
| | (0.058) | (0.056) | (0.054) | | |
| T2 × Moderator | −0.080 | −0.057 | −0.133** | | |
| | (0.070) | (0.069) | (0.065) | | |
| T3 × Moderator | 0.011 | 0.035 | −0.172** | | |
| | (0.085) | (0.081) | (0.080) | | |
| Constant | 0.698*** | 0.723*** | 0.622*** | 0.760*** | 0.603*** |
| | (0.071) | (0.066) | (0.072) | (0.082) | (0.098) |
| Moderator | Degree | Quiz mistake | Left-wing | | |
| Sample | All | All | All | Left-wing | Centre-right |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 928 | 466 | 462 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.088 | 0.090 | 0.093 | 0.096 | 0.083 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the choice of the Complex system. The independent variables are the treatment indicators, interacted in columns (1)–(3) with a moderator: having a Bachelor's degree or higher (column 1), an indicator for at least one incorrect answer on the eight comprehension questions (column 2), and an indicator for left-wing self-placement, 0–4 on a scale from 0 (left) to 10 (right) (column 3). Columns (4) and (5) estimate the treatment effects separately for left-wing and centre-right (5–10) spectators. All columns include controls, except education in column (1), where it is the moderator. The sample is the main sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

*The first exclusion weighs more* A further explanation, which the evidence below is consistent with, is that spectators' evaluation of the systems is not separable (Section 3): they value the Complex system for compensating *every* worker whose output was not fully registered, beyond the number of such workers it reaches, as under a perfection premium, or they judge each system by its worst-off worker, as under a Rawlsian criterion, so that the Complex system loses its advantage as soon as it leaves one such worker uncompensated.

Two pieces of evidence are consistent with this explanation. First, to see whether spectators judge the distributions differently once the Complex system no longer reaches

everyone, I use their rating of which system's distribution is fairer. Spectators rate the Complex system's distribution as less fair relative to the Simple system's in T3 (Appendix Table A1, Columns (3)–(4)),[20] although it still compensates one more worker whose output was not fully registered than the Simple system; under a separable evaluation, the fairness comparison would not change. The shift also appears among spectators who chose the Complex system (Appendix Table A3), so it is unlikely to reflect only post-choice rationalisation.[21] Second, to see which spectators decrease their support for the Complex system in T3, I split them by political self-placement. I use left-wing self-placement (0–4 on a scale from 0, left, to 10, right) as a proxy for concern for the worst-off and for distributional fairness (Alesina and Giuliano 2011; Cappelen, Cappelen, and Tungodden 2023b). In an exploratory analysis, the fall is concentrated among left-wing spectators (Table 3, Columns (3)–(5)). In T1, 75% of left-wing spectators choose the Complex system, against 59% of centre-right spectators (5–10 on the scale); in T3, their support falls to 52%, slightly below the 55% among centre-right spectators. With controls, this is a fall of 22 percentage points, against an insignificant 5 percentage points among centre-right spectators; the difference between the two groups is significant (interaction: $-0.17$, $p < 0.05$, Column (3)), also in the robustness sample (Appendix Table A15).[22] Left-wing spectators in T3 are also not more likely than centre-right spectators to regard missing out under the Complex system as more unfair (19% against 24%; $\chi^2(1) = 0.79$, $p = 0.37$), so their larger fall in support is unlikely to reflect procedural concerns. Among centre-right spectators, the fall in support is small and not statistically significant, consistent with the utilitarian benchmark of Section 3, under which support is the same in T1 and T3 (Prediction 2). The spectators most likely to choose the Complex system when it targets perfectly are those whose support falls most once it no longer reaches everyone. This suggests that the departure from the utilitarian benchmark is concentrated among left-wing spectators, who may care more about distributional fairness. The design cannot, however, distinguish between a premium on perfect targeting, diminishing sensitivity to targeting errors and a

[20] Spectators were asked which system's distribution of the compensation is fairer, from 0 (System A's distribution is much fairer) to 10 (System B's distribution is much fairer), and were instructed to base their answer only on who receives the compensation and who does not, ignoring all other properties of the two systems.

[21] The fairness rating also shifts in T2, where only the burden changes, which suggests some spillover from the burden to fairness judgements. Among spectators who chose the Complex system, however, the T2 shift is small and insignificant, while the T3 shift is large and significant. Moreover, because fewer spectators choose the Complex system in T3, those who still do are likely to be more favourable to it, which, if anything, biases the T3 shift among them towards zero.

[22] The results are robust to measuring political self-placement on the continuous 0–10 scale instead of splitting it at 4 (Appendix Table A16).

Rawlsian criterion, since all three predict the same choices in these treatments. Separating them is left to future research.

### 4.3. Choices and Policy Attitudes

To see whether choices in the experiment reflect spectators' views on real benefit systems, I regress four items collected after the choice on an indicator for implementing the Complex system, controlling for the treatment indicators, demographic characteristics, left-wing self-placement and generalised trust (Appendix Tables A4–A7). Spectators who implemented the Complex system place themselves 0.57 points closer to "benefits should be targeted, even if harder to claim" on the 0–10 trade-off scale: those willing to impose transaction costs on workers for accurate targeting also tend to favour targeting in real benefit systems. Support for the two simplification policies, a negative income tax and a universal basic income, is unrelated to the choice, plausibly because it turns on considerations the experiment holds fixed, such as cost and financing. Confidence in government is also unrelated to the choice: the decision does not simply track a general disposition towards the state and its administration.

## 5. Survey Experiment

The spectator experiment shows that the costs of complexity, both the effort it requires of claimants and its failure to reach everyone it is meant for, reduce support for complex systems. In a real welfare state, however, support for reform depends on many other factors, such as its fiscal cost, concerns about fraud, attitudes towards reform in general, and personal experience with the benefit system, and it is therefore an empirical question whether beliefs about these costs affect it. The survey experiment examines this question, focusing on three costs of complexity that are salient in the Dutch welfare state: non-take-up, the difficulty of understanding the rules, and the risk of having to pay back benefits.

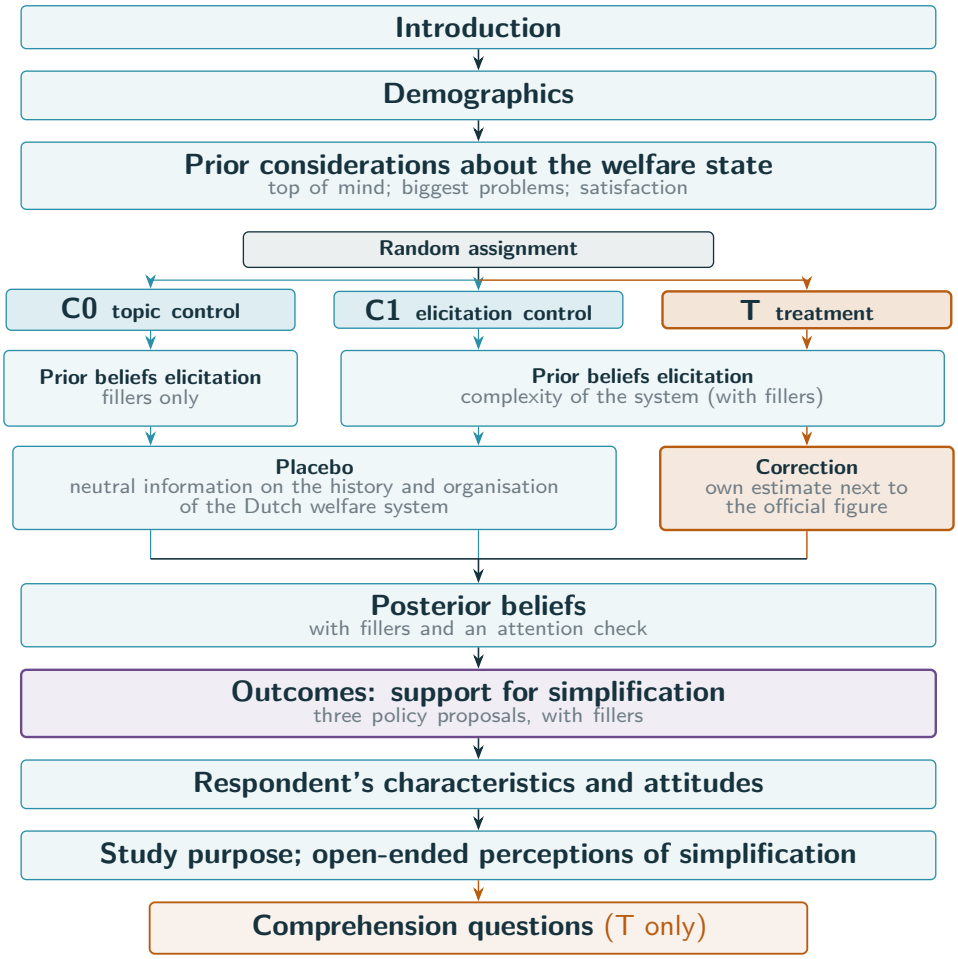
The Dutch welfare state provides support through many targeted tax credits, allowances, and benefits, and experts broadly agree that the system has become too complex for many citizens to manage (IBO Vereenvoudiging Sociale Zekerheid 2023; Kok et al. 2022; Centraal Planbureau and Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau 2020; Inspectie Belastingen, Toeslagen en Douane 2026). Simplification has long featured in election programmes across the political spectrum, yet the system remains in place (van Dijk 2026). This makes the Netherlands a natural setting to study whether information about the costs of complexity can build support for reform.

## 5.1. Experimental Design

### *5.1.1. Structure of the Survey*

Figure 3 shows the structure of the survey, and Appendix B.2 provides the full questionnaire. After reporting their baseline views, respondents are randomly assigned to one of three arms. In the treatment arm (T), I elicit their prior beliefs about three costs of complexity and then correct them; in the elicitation-control arm (C1), I elicit the same beliefs without correcting them; in the topic-control arm (C0), respondents estimate only unrelated quantities about the welfare state and read placebo information. To conceal the purpose of the study, I include filler questions in several blocks of the survey.

**Figure 3.** Outline of the survey experiment




*Baseline considerations.* After giving consent and reporting their age, gender, and education, respondents are told that the study concerns their opinions on and experiences with social security. They then rate their satisfaction with the welfare state, describe in open text what works well and what works poorly, and select its two most important problems from

a list that includes fraud, over-generosity, inadequacy, complicated rules, the number of schemes and agencies, and work disincentives (the fourth and fifth concern complexity).

*Prior beliefs.* Respondents in T and C1 then estimate, out of 100, three costs of complexity prominent in the Dutch system: how many people entitled to social assistance receive it (*non-take-up*; true figure 65, Inspectie SZW (2021)), how many allowance recipients correctly identified which assets they must report to the Benefits Agency (*understanding*; 26, Kok et al. (2022)), and how many rent-allowance households had to repay money or received an additional payment at the year-end reconciliation (*corrections*; 68, Centraal Planbureau (2019)).[23] All arms also answer two filler items that are never corrected, on the age of allowance recipients and the share of adults receiving benefits; these are the only items shown to C0. Items appear in random order.

I phrase all questions neutrally and never describe the phenomenon as a problem.[24] Rather than beliefs about the complexity of the welfare state as a whole, I elicit a few quantities that are most likely to shift beliefs about its costs. I therefore do not interpret gaps between these estimates and the true figures as systematic misperceptions of the complexity of the welfare state; measuring such misperceptions is left to future work.

*Information treatment.* Respondents then read short information screens with a minimum viewing time. In C0 and C1 these are placebo screens on the history and organisation of the Dutch welfare system. In T, each screen places the respondent's prior estimate next to the official figure and briefly explains how the cost relates to complexity.[25] Because respondents might otherwise attribute the costs to other causes, the treatment combines information with an interpretation of it, so its effect cannot be attributed to the information alone. I combine information on the three costs in a single treatment to maximise power.

*Posterior beliefs.* I do not re-elicit the corrected figures, which could capture recall and invite experimenter demand (Haaland, Roth, and Wohlfart 2023; Stantcheva 2023). Instead, all respondents rate whether having many separate schemes, each with its own rules, conditions, and application procedure, makes things better or worse for those entitled to

[23] In the Netherlands, allowances are paid in advance on the basis of the household's estimated income and circumstances, and recalculated at the end of the year. Because the rules are complicated and income is hard to predict, many households receive too much or too little and must repay the difference or receive an additional payment, and repayments can leave them in debt (Kok et al. 2022; IBO Vereenvoudiging Sociale Zekerheid 2023).

[24] For example, I ask how many entitled people *receive* a benefit rather than how many do not, and I avoid leading questions such as how many people "find the rules complicated".

[25] For example, the screen on year-end corrections notes that the Benefits Agency names the complexity of the allowance system as an important cause, since many people find it hard to estimate their annual income in advance.

support (0 = much worse, 10 = much better).[26] Respondents in C1 and T also answer the corrections question for the healthcare allowance, which the treatment does not mention ("Benefit corrections" in the tables); I do not ask this in C0, to avoid priming its respondents on the topic.

*Outcomes: support for simplification.* The main outcomes are support for three proposals, each rated from 0 (keep the current system) to 10 (fully support the change).[27] *Policy 1* consolidates the many benefits and allowances into fewer schemes, making the system easier to navigate at the cost of less accurately targeted support. *Policy 2*, from the government's review of alternatives to the allowance system, replaces most allowances with a single income-independent allowance, financed by abolishing tax credits and deductions (Ministerie van Financiën 2020; Dijksterhuis and van Baaren 2020). Like the choice in the spectator experiment, both trade simplicity against accurate targeting. *Policy 3* instead keeps all schemes in place and makes the consequences of mistakes milder, reducing the costs of complexity without sacrificing targeting. All proposals are presented as roughly budget-neutral and as not making it easier to obtain support without being entitled to it.

*Respondent characteristics and attitudes.* Finally, respondents report demographics and political attitudes, give their main arguments for and against the proposals, and say what they think the study is about and whether any part of the survey steered them towards a particular answer. Respondents in T also answer three comprehension questions.

### *5.1.2. Experimental Procedures, Comprehension, Demand Effects*

I conducted the survey with a sample of Dutch adults recruited through the online panel provider Bilendi, using quotas on age, gender, and education to match the Dutch adult population. Respondents received Bilendi's standard panel incentive, and the median completion time was 8.8 minutes. Of the 2,728 respondents who completed the survey, I exclude, as pre-registered, those who failed the instructed attention check or were among the fastest 5% within their arm, leaving an analysis sample of 2,212 (C0: 755; C1: 730; T: 727). The sample matches the Dutch adult population closely on gender and is somewhat older (51.8 against 49.1 years); as is common in online panels, respondents with a low level of education make up a smaller share than in the population (17.4% against 26.0%; Appendix Table A19).

Most treated respondents understood the correction: 72.6% identified its main message, and 58.8% correctly recalled the rent-allowance figure. Only 8.5% of respondents identified

[26] The block opens with two filler items, so that this question does not directly follow the information screens.
[27] The full wording of all proposals is provided in Appendix B.2.

the purpose of the study,[28] a share that does not increase with the treatment (Appendix Table A18); 12.0% felt steered by some part of the questionnaire, 4.3 percentage points more in T than in C0 ($p < 0.05$).

### 5.2. Results

*Beliefs about complexity.* Complexity is a common concern among respondents: 13% mention it spontaneously when asked what works well and what works poorly in the Dutch welfare state, and 58% select a complexity-related item as one of the system's biggest problems (Appendix Figure A7). As for their prior beliefs, respondents are roughly accurate about take-up of social assistance (mean 59.8 against 65), but overestimate how many recipients understand the asset rules (47.5 against 26) and underestimate how many rent-allowance households face year-end corrections (49.7 against 68; Appendix Figures A4–A6).

*Correlates of support for simplification.* Appendix Figure A8 and Appendix Table A23 report correlates of support for simplification and of beliefs about the harm of complexity, controlling for treatment. Beliefs about the harm of complexity and support for reform do not always go together. Compared with other respondents, those who find complexity salient and the highly educated see more harm and are more supportive of simplification; left-wing respondents and benefit recipients see more harm but are less supportive;[29] and respondents with high trust in government see less harm but are more supportive. Left-wing respondents and recipients are also more likely to name inadequate benefits as a main problem of the welfare state (Appendix Table A24), suggesting that they may oppose simplification out of concern that it could reduce benefits or targetting.

*Impact of the intervention on beliefs and policy support.* The intervention moves beliefs about the costs of complexity, but not support for simplification. Table 4 reports the effects.[30] The intervention makes respondents see complexity as more harmful for claimants: it lowers their rating by 0.599 points on the 0–10 scale ($p < 0.01$). Column (2) shows that treated respondents raise their estimate of year-end corrections in the healthcare allowance by 6.18 points ($p < 0.01$). However, this belief change does not translate into

[28] I code the open-ended answers with a large language model, using the GABRIEL package (Asirvatham, Mokski, and Shleifer 2026) with three runs and a majority rule. An answer counts as identifying the purpose if it states that the study is about support for simplifying the benefits system.

[29] Similarly, in the spectator experiment, left-wing spectators are more likely to choose the Complex system in T1 (Section 4).

[30] Throughout, I report the effect of the full intervention (T vs. C0), which combines eliciting beliefs with correcting them, as merely eliciting beliefs has no effect on any outcome (C1 vs. C0). The T vs. C1 contrast is reported in Tables 4 and 5.

policy preferences (columns 3–5). The effect on policy support also does not differ between respondents who underestimated these costs and those who did not (Appendix Tables A20–A22). That beliefs move more easily than policy preferences is a common finding in information provision experiments (Haaland and Roth 2023; Haaland, Roth, and Wohlfart 2023; Kuziemko et al. 2015).

**Table 4.** Treatment effects on beliefs and policy support

| | Beliefs | | Policy support (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Complexity helps claimants | Benefit corrections (0–100) | Policy 1: simpler system | Policy 2: basistoeslag | Policy 3: milder consequences |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) |
| Treatment (T) | −0.599*** | 6.182*** | 0.160 | 0.146 | 0.160 |
| | (0.110) | (1.036) | (0.117) | (0.139) | (0.128) |
| Elicitation (C1) | −0.050 | — | 0.045 | 0.183 | 0.141 |
| | (0.109) | | (0.119) | (0.139) | (0.131) |
| Constant | 6.208*** | 60.713*** | 6.013*** | 6.207*** | 6.219*** |
| | (0.194) | (2.120) | (0.199) | (0.234) | (0.216) |
| $p$-value: T = C1 | <0.001 | — | 0.35 | 0.79 | 0.88 |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Omitted category | C0 | C1 | C0 | C0 | C0 |
| Observations | 2,212 | 1,457 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.057 | 0.075 | 0.016 | 0.029 | 0.008 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are: *Complexity helps claimants*, whether the many separate schemes, each with its own rules, conditions and application procedure, make things better or worse for people entitled to support, from 0 (much worse) through 5 (no difference) to 10 (much better), so a negative coefficient means the system is seen as more harmful; *Benefit corrections*, the estimated number of every 100 zorgtoeslag (healthcare allowance) recipients who had to repay or receive extra at the end of the year; and support for Policy 1 (a simpler system with fewer, more general schemes), Policy 2 (a single basistoeslag replacing all allowances except the childcare allowance) and Policy 3 (milder consequences of mistakes), each from 0 (keep the current system as it is) to 10 (fully support this change). The independent variables are indicators for the treatment arm (T; prior beliefs elicited and corrected) and the elicitation control arm (C1; prior beliefs elicited, no correction). Controls are age (in years), an indicator for being female, an indicator for high education (hbo or wo), and an indicator for a net yearly household income of at least EUR 40,000. The sample (analysis sample) consists of respondents who completed the survey, passed the attention check and were not among the fastest 5% within their arm. In columns (1) and (3)–(5), the topic control (C0) is omitted. Benefit corrections were elicited only in C1 and T, so column (2) uses these two arms with C1 omitted. The $p$-value is from a Wald test that the coefficients on T and C1 are equal. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

*Heterogeneity in responses to the intervention.* To examine whether the null average effect on policy support hides differences between groups, I estimate heterogeneous treatment effects by respondent characteristics (Appendix Table A26). For Policy 1, the treatment effect is smaller for benefit recipients and for the highly educated. In case of Policy 2, it

does not vary with any characteristic. For Policy 3, which would soften the consequences of mistakes without reducing targeting, the treatment increases support among respondents who see complexity as a problem, those less concerned with fraud, and those with higher incomes.

Since Policy 1, unlike Policy 3, involves the trade-off between simplicity and accurate targeting that the spectator experiment studies, I examine its heterogeneous effects further. I first consider education, one of the two characteristics for which the effect on Policy 1 differs, splitting the sample into respondents with a tertiary degree (hbo or wo; the highly educated) and all others (the lower educated). Both groups update their beliefs (Appendix Tables A34 and A35), but only the lower educated also change their policy views: the treatment raises their support for a simpler system by 0.37 points.[31]

A likely explanation is that the highly educated start from a different baseline. Their prior beliefs about the costs of complexity are as inaccurate as those of the lower educated (Appendix Table A25), but they are more likely to name complexity as one of the main problems of the system (Appendix Table A24), see the rules as more harmful, and are more supportive of a simpler system regardless of the treatment (Appendix Table A23). This is consistent with evidence that more educated individuals hold more stable and constrained political attitudes (Converse 1964; Zaller 1992). Their open-ended justifications of their policy view also suggest that they weigh costs of complexity against other considerations: they are more likely to mention costs and efficiency and the risk that a reform would increase fraud (Appendix Table A32), which may offset the case for simplification made by the information. They are, however, also more likely to mention complexity and bureaucracy (by 7.2 percentage points).

I next turn to benefit receipt. Benefit recipients are respondents who have ever received at least one of the listed benefits or allowances, excluding the state pension (61% of the sample), a measure that also captures likely future receipt (IBO Vereenvoudiging Sociale Zekerheid 2023). At baseline, recipients differ from non-recipients in how they view the system. They are less supportive of the two policies that reduce targeting and more supportive of milder consequences for mistakes (Appendix Table A23). They are also less likely to name complexity as one of the main problems of the system, and more likely to say that benefits are too low (Appendix Table A24).

The correction moves the beliefs of both recipients and non-recipients. After the correction, recipients see the system as more harmful for the people entitled to support

[31]The pattern is unlikely to be driven by experimenter demand, as it holds when I exclude respondents who guessed the purpose of the study or felt steered (Appendix Table A36), or by inattention, as education is unrelated to passing the attention check or to inclusion in the analysis sample (Appendix Table A31).

(by 0.71 points, against 0.39 points for non-recipients; Table 5), and both groups raise their estimate of year-end corrections in healthcare allowance by a similar amount (Appendix Table A27). Yet only non-recipients change their policy views. The treatment increases their support for a simpler system by 0.48 points, while the effect among recipients is close to zero, even though both groups have a similar baseline level of support (5.9 against 6.0 in the topic-control arm, on the 0–10 scale).[32] Recipients' prior beliefs about the costs of complexity also do not differ from those of non-recipients (Appendix Table A25), so differences in prior beliefs cannot explain why the two groups respond differently to the correction.

The pattern is unlikely to be driven by experimenter demand, as it is also the same when I exclude respondents who guessed the purpose of the study or felt steered (Appendix Table A30). Inattention is also unlikely: recipients are about six percentage points more likely than non-recipients to pass the attention check and to be included in the analysis sample (Appendix Table A31), and they update their beliefs as much as non-recipients. Another possibility is that recipients have experienced the complexity themselves and do not see it as a serious problem. However, among recipients the treatment effect does not vary with the complexity of the schemes they have received (Appendix Table A29): what matters is receiving benefits at all, not how much complexity one has experienced. Finally, the pattern is not explained by observable differences between recipients and non-recipients: when the treatment effect may vary with all respondent characteristics at once, the benefit receipt interaction remains negative and significant (Appendix Table A28).

As a possible explanation of these results, the open-ended answers point to a personal stake in the system and to uncertainty about how a reform would affect recipients (Appendix Table A32). Compared with non-recipients, recipients are more likely to say that a reform could cut their support, to mention the loss of targeted support, and to reason from their own situation.[33] This is not because recipients believe that complexity is not costly: they consider the many separate schemes more harmful than non-recipients do (Appendix Table A23). An alternative explanation is that recipients already know more about the costs of complexity than the survey measures, so that the information adds little to their knowledge. If so, however, their prior beliefs should be more accurate and the

[32] These are effects of the full intervention, which combines eliciting beliefs with correcting them. Compared with the elicitation-control arm, the difference between recipients and non-recipients has the same sign but is smaller and not statistically significant.

[33] The results replicate on the subsample of respondents who gave a substantive answer (Appendix Table A33).

information should move them less. Instead, their prior beliefs are as inaccurate as those of non-recipients, and the information moves them at least as much.

The difference in policy responses between recipients and non-recipients is specific to a general simplification of the system: for Policies 2 and 3, the information raises support in neither group (Appendix Table A26). The two proposals differ from Policy 1 in different ways. Policy 2 replaces most allowances with a single allowance for all households, financed by abolishing tax credits and deductions, so respondents may find it harder to tell how it would affect them. Policy 3 keeps targeted support, so it does not involve the trade-off between simplicity and accurate targeting, and it leaves recipients' benefits unchanged.

Taken together, correcting beliefs about the costs of complexity is not enough on its own to raise support for simplification. Respondents underestimate these costs and update their beliefs when informed, but only non-recipients, who have no personal stake in the system, become more supportive of a simpler system, similar to the impartial spectators in Section 4. Recipients update their beliefs but not their support, possibly because their own stake in the system, and uncertainty about how a reform would affect them, weighs more heavily than the costs of complexity.

**Table 5.** Treatment effects on beliefs and policy support, by benefit receipt

| | Complexity helps claimants | | Policy 1: simpler system | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Non-recipients | Recipients | Non-recipients | Recipients |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| Treatment (T) | -0.386** | -0.709*** | 0.480*** | -0.039 |
| | (0.164) | (0.135) | (0.174) | (0.155) |
| Elicitation (C1) | -0.069 | -0.093 | 0.204 | -0.062 |
| | (0.160) | (0.135) | (0.181) | (0.155) |
| Constant | 4.997*** | 4.877*** | 5.530*** | 5.712*** |
| | (0.308) | (0.280) | (0.332) | (0.317) |
| $p$-value: T = C1 | 0.065 | <0.001 | 0.128 | 0.890 |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.138 | 0.178 | 0.021 | 0.029 |
| Observations | 865 | 1,347 | 865 | 1,347 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are Complexity helps claimants (columns 1 and 2) and support for Policy 1 (columns 3 and 4). The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators; C0 is omitted. Controls are age, female, high education, higher income, an indicator for left-wing self-placement (0–4 on a scale from 0, left, to 10, right), and trust in the government and public institutions (0–10). The sample is the analysis sample, split into benefit recipients, who have ever received at least one of 16 listed benefit schemes (AOW excluded), and non-recipients. The $p$-value is from a Wald test that the coefficients on T and C1 are equal. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

## 6. Conclusion

Complexity of benefit systems improves the accuracy of targeting, but imposes transaction costs on claimants. This paper provides insight into why, despite political appetite for simplification in many countries, progress on reform has been slow.

First, the spectator experiment shows that people accept a high price for accurate targeting: two thirds of spectators choose a system in which eight workers spend 56 unpaid minutes in total so that one payment reaches a deserving worker. This means that proposed reforms that sacrifice targeting may be unpopular.

Second, the two experiments point to different binding constraints on simplification. When people judge the trade-off impartially, as the spectators or benefit non-recipients do, their support for complexity depends on its costs. Informing people outside of the system about them might therefore be an effective way to boost their support for a simpler system. However, when people have a personal stake in the system, as benefit recipients do, the constraint appears to be different. Recipients update their beliefs about the costs of complexity at least as much as non-recipients, but do not change their support. For them, the constraint may instead be uncertainty about how a reform would affect their own benefits. Simplification may create uncertainty about who would gain and who would lose from the policy change, and such uncertainty can sustain support for the status quo (Fernandez and Rodrik 1991).

Support for complexity, however, depends on the complex system reaching everyone it is meant for. In the spectator experiment, a single exclusion error reduces support for the Complex system, even though its targetting advantage is kept constant. If the public evaluates real benefit systems in a similar way, exclusion in complex systems weakens the fairness argument that justifies complexity in the first place.[34] This may be particularly relevant for gaining the support of left-wing voters, who in both experiments are more supportive of complexity, but whose support in the spectator experiment substantially falls once the complex system no longer reaches everyone. An interesting avenue for future research is to understand why this single exclusion error matters so much, since my design does not distinguish between a premium on perfect targeting, diminishing sensitivity to targeting errors and a Rawlsian concern for the worst-off.

Apart from resolving uncertainty about the distributional effects of simplification reforms, another possible way forward may be to keep accurate targeting but reduce the

[34]The information in the survey experiment also covered non-take-up and did not raise average support for simplification. Respondents' beliefs about non-take-up were, however, already close to the official figure (59.8 against 65 out of every 100 people entitled to social assistance), so this part of the information told them little they did not already know.

costs that complexity imposes on claimants. These costs are not a problem the public overlooks. Even without any information, 48% of Dutch respondents in the control group think that the many separate schemes make things worse for people entitled to support, against 30% who think they make things better, and 58% of all respondents name complexity as one of the main problems of the welfare state. There may therefore be broad support for measures that keep targeting but reduce these costs. Such measures would shift the costs of complexity from claimants onto the state, for example through more staff and advisers who help claimants navigate the system, outreach to people who are entitled to support but do not claim it, and linking administrative data across agencies. Recent advances in AI may also make it possible for governments to develop cost-effective tools that explain the rules, check entitlements across schemes and help claimants complete their applications.

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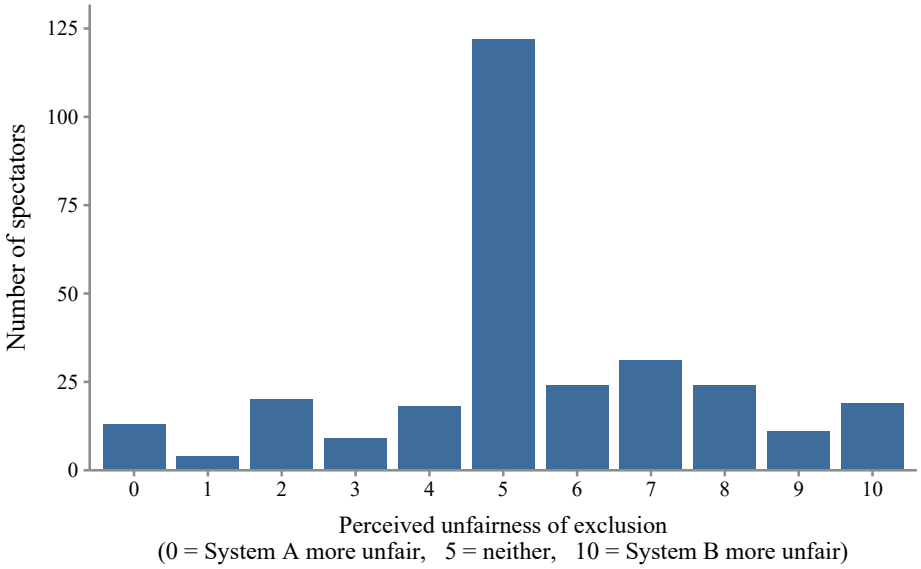
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# Appendices

## A. Additional Tables and Figures

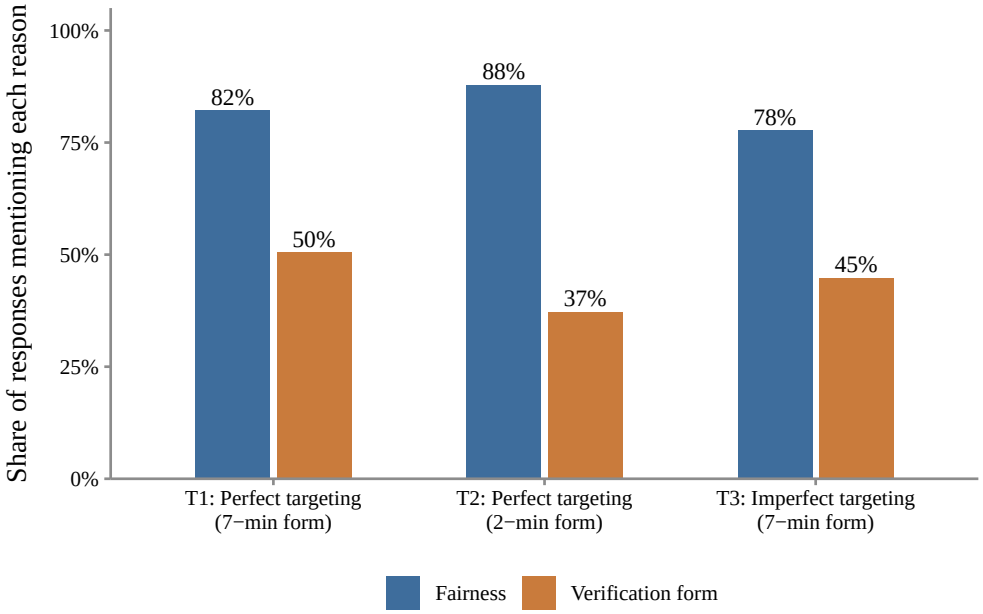
### A.1. Spectator experiment

**Figure A1.** Perceived unfairness of exclusion in T3



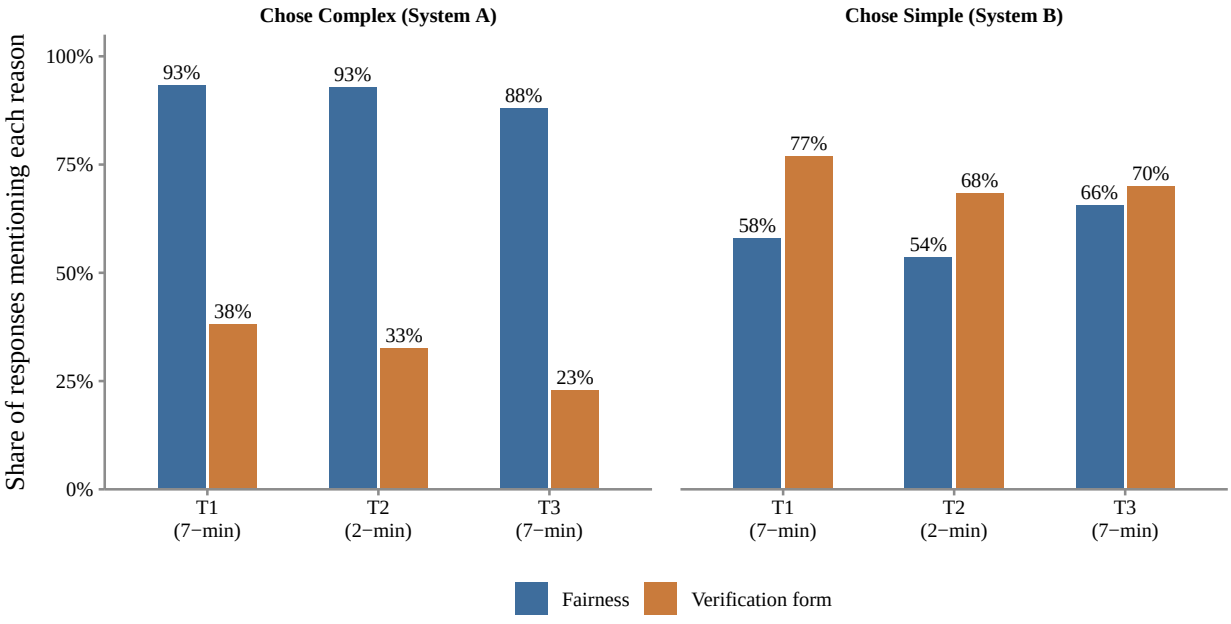

*Notes.* Spectators in T3 rated whether missing out on the compensation is more unfair under System A or System B, from 0 (System A much more unfair) to 10 (System B much more unfair). Bars show the number of spectators giving each response. $N = 295$.

**Figure A2.** Reasons mentioned by spectators, by treatment




*Notes.* Share of spectators whose open-ended justification of their choice mentions the fairness of the distribution or the verification form, coded with a large language model. A response can mention both, so the shares within a treatment need not sum to 100%.

**Figure A3.** Reasons mentioned by spectators, by chosen system and treatment




*Notes.* As in Figure A2, separately for spectators who chose the Complex system (System A, left) and the Simple system (System B, right). These comparisons condition on the choice, which the treatment affects.

**Table A1.** Perceived effort and fairness

| | Perceived effort | | Perceived fairness (B vs. A) | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| T2 (low cost) | $-2.342^{***}$ | $-2.380^{***}$ | $-0.678^{***}$ | $-0.632^{***}$ |
| | (0.169) | (0.169) | (0.205) | (0.204) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | $0.311^{*}$ | $0.305^{*}$ | $1.155^{***}$ | $1.152^{***}$ |
| | (0.176) | (0.176) | (0.220) | (0.220) |
| Constant | $6.649^{***}$ | $6.174^{***}$ | $2.588^{***}$ | $3.041^{***}$ |
| | (0.120) | (0.320) | (0.154) | (0.379) |
| Controls | | ✓ | | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 928 | 928 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.232 | 0.235 | 0.075 | 0.085 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are perceived effort (columns 1 and 2), how much more effort System A (verification form) requires than System B (automatic) for workers to receive the compensation, from 0 (no extra effort) to 10 (far more effort), and perceived fairness (columns 3 and 4), which system's distribution of the compensation is fairer, from 0 (System A's much fairer) to 10 (System B's much fairer), so higher values mean the Complex system is judged less fair. The independent variables are the treatment indicators; columns (2) and (4) add controls. The sample is the main sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A2.** Choice of the Complex system, controlling for perceived effort

| | Chose Complex (System A) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Main sample | | Robustness sample | |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| T2 (low cost) | $0.190^{***}$ | $0.062^{*}$ | $0.175^{***}$ | 0.031 |
| | (0.032) | (0.035) | (0.035) | (0.036) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | $-0.145^{***}$ | $-0.129^{***}$ | $-0.190^{***}$ | $-0.159^{***}$ |
| | (0.039) | (0.038) | (0.045) | (0.043) |
| Perceived effort | | $-0.053^{***}$ | | $-0.056^{***}$ |
| | | (0.006) | | (0.007) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.088 | 0.150 | 0.106 | 0.178 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the choice of the Complex system. Columns (2) and (4) add perceived effort, spectators' rating of how much more effort the Complex system requires of workers than the Simple system, from 0 (no extra effort) to 10 (far more effort). Perceived effort is elicited after the choice, so its coefficient is a correlation. Controls are age, gender, education, income, and whether the respondent has ever received benefits. The reference category is T1. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A3.** Perceived fairness, by chosen system

| | Perceived fairness (B vs. A) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Chose Complex (System A) | | Chose Simple (System B) | |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.205 | −0.198 | 0.604 | 0.801 |
| | (0.172) | (0.172) | (0.566) | (0.557) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.724*** | 0.692*** | 0.710* | 0.769** |
| | (0.213) | (0.216) | (0.368) | (0.378) |
| Constant | 1.624*** | 1.803*** | 4.640*** | 6.121*** |
| | (0.131) | (0.341) | (0.307) | (0.751) |
| Controls | | ✓ | | ✓ |
| Observations | 650 | 650 | 278 | 278 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.032 | 0.040 | 0.007 | 0.024 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is perceived fairness. The independent variables are the treatment indicators; columns (2) and (4) add controls. The sample is the main sample, restricted to spectators who chose the Complex system in columns (1) and (2) and to those who chose the Simple system in columns (3) and (4). Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A4.** Choice and preference for targeting

| | Preference for targeting (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | 0.461** | 0.504** | 0.574*** |
| | (0.210) | (0.207) | (0.199) |
| T2 (low cost) | 0.131 | 0.107 | 0.015 |
| | (0.221) | (0.220) | (0.214) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.167 | 0.210 | 0.082 |
| | (0.229) | (0.226) | (0.220) |
| Constant | 5.657*** | 4.874*** | 5.680*** |
| | (0.208) | (0.415) | (0.412) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 928 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.043 | 0.100 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the preference for targeting, from 0 ("benefits should be universal and easier to claim") to 10 ("benefits should be targeted, even if harder to claim"). The independent variables are an indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. Demographic controls (columns 2 and 3) are the controls used in the previous tables. Attitudinal controls (column 3) are an indicator for left-wing self-placement and an indicator for generalised trust of 6 or above on a scale from 0 ("you can't be too careful") to 10 ("most people can be trusted"). The sample is the main sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A5.** Choice and support for a negative income tax

| | Support for NIT (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | 0.044 | 0.023 | −0.030 |
| | (0.217) | (0.216) | (0.212) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.224 | −0.180 | −0.112 |
| | (0.232) | (0.232) | (0.230) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | −0.109 | −0.121 | −0.024 |
| | (0.234) | (0.233) | (0.230) |
| Constant | 5.245*** | 6.376*** | 5.774*** |
| | (0.208) | (0.439) | (0.445) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 928 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | −0.002 | 0.003 | 0.032 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is support for a negative income tax (NIT), described to respondents as a policy that pays money to people on low incomes based on income data the government already holds, with no application and nothing to report, and which does not adjust for circumstances such as rent or who they live with; it is measured from 0 ("keep the current system as it is") to 10 ("fully support this change"). The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the main sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A6.** Choice and support for a universal basic income

| | Support for UBI (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | −0.327 | −0.330 | −0.363 |
| | (0.233) | (0.234) | (0.232) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.155 | −0.123 | −0.075 |
| | (0.239) | (0.239) | (0.238) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | −0.182 | −0.144 | −0.085 |
| | (0.247) | (0.246) | (0.248) |
| Constant | 4.012*** | 4.388*** | 3.976*** |
| | (0.230) | (0.453) | (0.463) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 928 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | −0.000 | 0.008 | 0.020 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is support for a universal basic income (UBI), described to respondents as a policy that pays every adult resident the same monthly amount, enough to cover basic living costs, paid automatically with no application and nothing to report, and which also goes to people who do not need it and is therefore more expensive; it is measured on the same 0–10 scale as support for NIT. The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the main sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A7.** Choice and confidence in government

| | Confidence in government (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | 0.110 | 0.122 | 0.117 |
| | (0.127) | (0.127) | (0.124) |
| T2 (low cost) | 0.009 | 0.047 | 0.090 |
| | (0.135) | (0.135) | (0.130) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.261* | 0.297** | 0.303** |
| | (0.137) | (0.135) | (0.130) |
| Constant | 4.296*** | 4.220*** | 3.874*** |
| | (0.120) | (0.255) | (0.244) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 928 | 928 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.021 | 0.107 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is confidence in government, the mean of four items each measured on a 0–10 disagree–agree scale: trust in the civil service and government departments; whether government departments are generally able to run public services efficiently; whether the rules and procedures they follow usually serve a real purpose; and whether they waste a lot of money through errors and mismanagement (reverse-coded). The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the main sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A8.** Choice of the Complex system (robustness sample)

| | Chose Complex (System A) | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| T2 (low cost) | $0.179^{***}$ | $0.175^{***}$ |
| | (0.035) | (0.035) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | $-0.187^{***}$ | $-0.190^{***}$ |
| | (0.045) | (0.045) |
| Constant | $0.715^{***}$ | $0.750^{***}$ |
| | (0.029) | (0.068) |
| Controls | | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.106 | 0.106 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the choice of the Complex system. The independent variables are the treatment indicators; column (2) adds controls. The sample is the pre-registered robustness sample, which excludes from the main sample spectators in the bottom 5% of completion time within their treatment and spectators with more than one incorrect answer on the eight comprehension questions. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A9.** Perceived effort and fairness (robustness sample)

| | Perceived effort | | Perceived fairness (B vs. A) | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| T2 (low cost) | $-2.540^{***}$ | $-2.575^{***}$ | $-0.646^{***}$ | $-0.618^{***}$ |
| | (0.188) | (0.188) | (0.209) | (0.212) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | $0.569^{***}$ | $0.563^{***}$ | $1.412^{***}$ | $1.411^{***}$ |
| | (0.208) | (0.207) | (0.243) | (0.244) |
| Constant | $6.642^{***}$ | $6.267^{***}$ | $2.203^{***}$ | $2.659^{***}$ |
| | (0.136) | (0.356) | (0.162) | (0.398) |
| Controls | | ✓ | | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.284 | 0.286 | 0.105 | 0.108 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are perceived effort (columns 1 and 2) and perceived fairness (columns 3 and 4). The independent variables are the treatment indicators; columns (2) and (4) add controls. The sample is the robustness sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A10.** Perceived fairness, by chosen system (robustness sample)

| | Perceived fairness (B vs. A) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Chose Complex (System A) | | Chose Simple (System B) | |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.276 | −0.278 | 0.527 | 0.761 |
| | (0.175) | (0.177) | (0.694) | (0.713) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.632*** | 0.603*** | 1.278*** | 1.320*** |
| | (0.215) | (0.219) | (0.448) | (0.469) |
| Constant | 1.477*** | 1.715*** | 4.029*** | 5.580*** |
| | (0.136) | (0.342) | (0.376) | (0.919) |
| Controls | | ✓ | | ✓ |
| Observations | 514 | 514 | 195 | 195 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.035 | 0.034 | 0.034 | 0.038 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is perceived fairness. The independent variables are the treatment indicators; columns (2) and (4) add controls. The sample is the robustness sample, restricted to spectators who chose the Complex system in columns (1) and (2) and to those who chose the Simple system in columns (3) and (4). Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A11.** Choice and preference for targeting (robustness sample)

| | Preference for targeting (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | 0.551** | 0.603** | 0.702*** |
| | (0.246) | (0.244) | (0.234) |
| T2 (low cost) | 0.244 | 0.206 | 0.087 |
| | (0.248) | (0.248) | (0.243) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.304 | 0.335 | 0.231 |
| | (0.259) | (0.256) | (0.249) |
| Constant | 5.577*** | 4.821*** | 5.655*** |
| | (0.244) | (0.474) | (0.478) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.006 | 0.037 | 0.096 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the preference for targeting. The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the robustness sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A12.** Choice and support for a negative income tax (robustness sample)

| | Support for NIT (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | −0.157 | −0.165 | −0.235 |
| | (0.251) | (0.250) | (0.246) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.254 | −0.209 | −0.124 |
| | (0.259) | (0.258) | (0.257) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | −0.103 | −0.102 | −0.033 |
| | (0.270) | (0.267) | (0.265) |
| Constant | 5.446*** | 6.548*** | 5.956*** |
| | (0.240) | (0.486) | (0.496) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | −0.002 | 0.003 | 0.030 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is support for NIT. The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the robustness sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A13.** Choice and support for a universal basic income (robustness sample)

| | Support for UBI (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | −0.393 | −0.374 | −0.440 |
| | (0.275) | (0.274) | (0.271) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.044 | −0.029 | 0.051 |
| | (0.267) | (0.265) | (0.263) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | −0.221 | −0.190 | −0.123 |
| | (0.287) | (0.282) | (0.283) |
| Constant | 3.948*** | 4.470*** | 3.913*** |
| | (0.273) | (0.512) | (0.517) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | −0.001 | 0.015 | 0.036 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is support for UBI. The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the robustness sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A14.** Choice and confidence in government (robustness sample)

| | Confidence in government (0–10) | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Chose Complex (System A) | −0.007 | 0.034 | −0.000 |
| | (0.150) | (0.150) | (0.147) |
| T2 (low cost) | −0.151 | −0.113 | −0.054 |
| | (0.152) | (0.153) | (0.147) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.212 | 0.251 | 0.232 |
| | (0.156) | (0.154) | (0.147) |
| Constant | 4.450*** | 4.233*** | 3.884*** |
| | (0.143) | (0.289) | (0.278) |
| Demographic controls | | ✓ | ✓ |
| Attitudinal controls | | | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.019 | 0.107 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is confidence in government. The independent variables are the indicator for having chosen the Complex system and the treatment indicators. The sample is the robustness sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A15.** Choice of the Complex system: heterogeneity (robustness sample)

| | Chose Complex (System A) | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Interaction with moderator | | | Split sample | |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) |
| T2 (low cost) | $0.271^{***}$ | $0.212^{***}$ | $0.254^{***}$ | $0.124^{***}$ | $0.256^{***}$ |
| | (0.062) | (0.039) | (0.058) | (0.042) | (0.058) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | $-0.179^{**}$ | $-0.167^{***}$ | $-0.063$ | $-0.290^{***}$ | $-0.061$ |
| | (0.084) | (0.053) | (0.069) | (0.061) | (0.069) |
| Moderator | 0.039 | 0.074 | $0.166^{***}$ | | |
| | (0.066) | (0.067) | (0.060) | | |
| T2 × Moderator | $-0.136^{*}$ | $-0.159^{*}$ | $-0.128^{*}$ | | |
| | (0.075) | (0.085) | (0.071) | | |
| T3 × Moderator | $-0.013$ | $-0.100$ | $-0.227^{**}$ | | |
| | (0.100) | (0.101) | (0.092) | | |
| Constant | $0.716^{***}$ | $0.729^{***}$ | $0.647^{***}$ | $0.777^{***}$ | $0.666^{***}$ |
| | (0.078) | (0.070) | (0.079) | (0.088) | (0.109) |
| Moderator | Degree | Quiz mistake | Left-wing | | |
| Sample | All | All | All | Left-wing | Centre-right |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 709 | 709 | 709 | 375 | 334 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.108 | 0.106 | 0.116 | 0.142 | 0.080 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the choice of the Complex system. The independent variables are the treatment indicators, interacted in columns (1)–(3) with a moderator: having a Bachelor's degree or higher (column 1), at least one incorrect comprehension answer (column 2), and left-wing self-placement (column 3). Columns (4) and (5) estimate the treatment effects separately for left-wing and centre-right spectators. All columns include controls, except education in column (1). The sample is the robustness sample; in column (2), the comparison is therefore between spectators with no and with one incorrect answer. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A16.** Choice of the Complex system: heterogeneity by political self-placement on the continuous scale

| | Chose Complex (System A) | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| T2 (low cost) | $0.402^{***}$ | $0.398^{***}$ |
| | (0.097) | (0.110) |
| T3 (imperfect targeting) | 0.171 | $0.233^{*}$ |
| | (0.108) | (0.128) |
| Left scale | $0.035^{***}$ | $0.043^{***}$ |
| | (0.012) | (0.014) |
| T2 $\times$ Left scale | $-0.036^{**}$ | $-0.037^{**}$ |
| | (0.015) | (0.017) |
| T3 $\times$ Left scale | $-0.055^{***}$ | $-0.072^{***}$ |
| | (0.017) | (0.020) |
| Constant | $0.496^{***}$ | $0.486^{***}$ |
| | (0.100) | (0.112) |
| Sample | Main | Robustness |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 928 | 709 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.097 | 0.123 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is the choice of the Complex system. The treatment indicators are interacted with political self-placement on the continuous 0–10 scale, reversed so that 0 is right and 10 is left (Left scale). The coefficients on T2 and T3 are therefore the treatment effects for spectators at the right end of the scale. Controls are age, gender, education, income, and whether the respondent has ever received benefits. Column (1) uses the main sample, column (2) the robustness sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

## A.2. Survey experiment

**Table A17.** Sample exclusion, by arm

| Arm | Completers | In sample | Excluded | Excluded (%) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| C0 (topic control) | 916 | 755 | 161 | 17.6 |
| C1 (elicitation control) | 908 | 730 | 178 | 19.6 |
| T (treatment) | 904 | 727 | 177 | 19.6 |
| Total | 2,728 | 2,212 | 516 | 18.9 |

**Table A18.** Exclusion, guessing the purpose, and feeling steered, by arm

| | Excluded | Guessed purpose | | Felt steered |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | Strict | Broad | |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.020 | -0.019 | -0.017 | -0.003 |
| | (0.018) | (0.014) | (0.024) | (0.016) |
| Treatment (T) | 0.020 | -0.006 | -0.026 | 0.043** |
| | (0.018) | (0.015) | (0.024) | (0.017) |
| Constant | 0.176*** | 0.093*** | 0.336*** | 0.107*** |
| | (0.013) | (0.011) | (0.017) | (0.011) |
| Observations | 2,728 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | -0.000 | -0.000 | -0.000 | 0.003 |

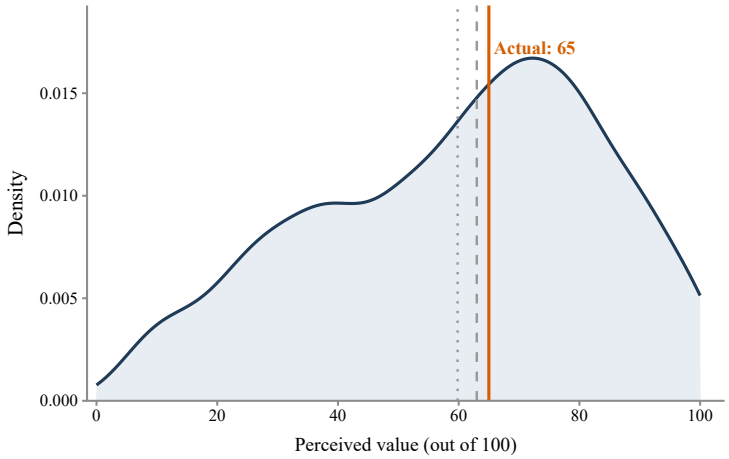
*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions (linear probability models) where the dependent variables are indicators for: being excluded from the analysis sample (column 1); an open-ended answer that identifies the purpose of the study as support for simplifying the benefits system (column 2, strict coding) or as reforming the system or testing whether information changes opinions (column 3, broad coding); and reporting that some part of the questionnaire steered the respondent toward an answer (column 4). Open-ended answers are LLM-coded. The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators; C0 is omitted. The sample is all respondents who completed the survey in column (1) and the analysis sample in columns (2)–(4). Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A19.** Sample composition and the Dutch adult population

| | Sample | Dutch population |
|---|---|---|
| Age (mean, years) | 51.8 | 49.1 |
| Female | 0.506 | 0.505 |
| *Education* | | |
| Low | 0.174 | 0.260 |
| Mid | 0.430 | 0.370 |
| High | 0.396 | 0.364 |
| Observations | 2,212 | |

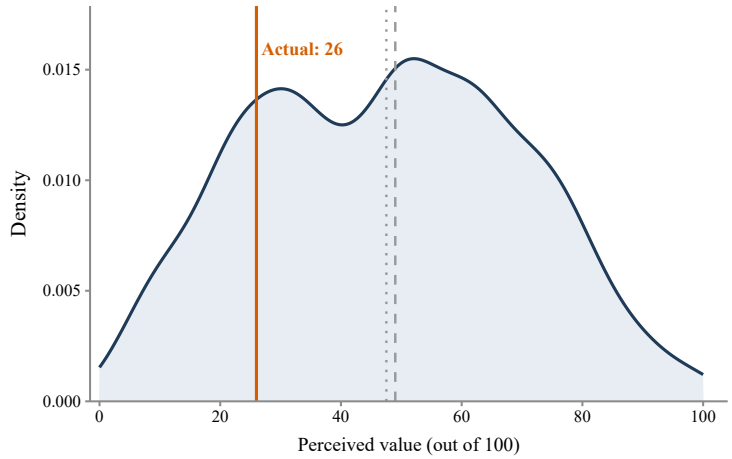
*Notes.* The sample is the analysis sample. Education follows the CBS classification — Low: primary education, VMBO, MBO-1; Mid: HAVO/VWO diploma, MBO-2/3/4; High: HBO, university (WO) — with shares computed over the 2,204 respondents with a known education level (8 respondents answering "other / don't know" are excluded). Female is the share reporting "Vrouw". Dutch-population figures are from CBS: mean age for those aged 16 and over and the female share for those aged 15 and over in 2026 (StatLine), and education shares from *The Netherlands in Numbers 2024*.

**Figure A4.** Non-take-up: perceived share of entitled who receive bijstand vs. the true value (65).



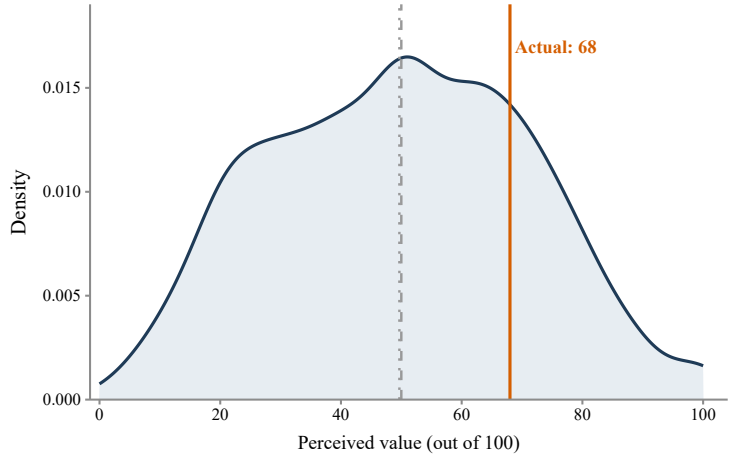

*Notes.* Distribution of respondents' prior beliefs in the arms where priors were elicited (C1 and T). The dotted line marks the mean, the dashed line the median, and the orange line the true value.

**Figure A5.** Understanding own rules: perceived share who answer the assets question correctly vs. the true value (26).



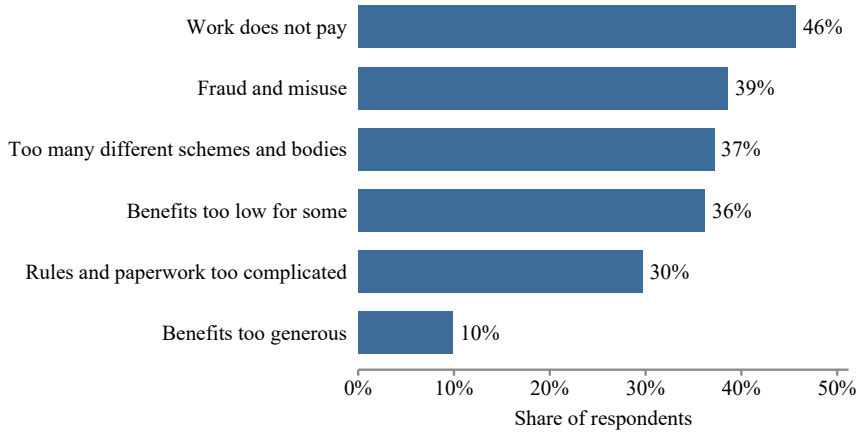

*Notes.* As in Figure A4.

**Figure A6.** Retroactive corrections: perceived share of huurtoeslag households corrected vs. the true value (68).




*Notes.* As in Figure A4.

**Figure A7.** Which problems respondents find most salient at baseline ("select exactly two").




*Notes.* Share of respondents selecting each item when asked to choose exactly two of the biggest problems of the Dutch welfare state, so the shares sum to 200%. $N = 2{,}212$.

**Table A20.** Treatment effects on policy support, by prior underestimation

| | Policy 1: simpler system | Policy 2: basistoeslag | Policy 3: milder consequences |
|---|---|---|---|
| Treatment (T) | 0.239 | −0.008 | 0.290 |
| | (0.199) | (0.239) | (0.223) |
| Underestimator | −0.262 | −0.053 | 0.244 |
| | (0.178) | (0.205) | (0.198) |
| T × Underestimator | −0.173 | −0.044 | −0.411 |
| | (0.251) | (0.294) | (0.272) |
| Constant | 6.325*** | 6.185*** | 6.142*** |
| | (0.247) | (0.304) | (0.272) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 1,457 | 1,457 | 1,457 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.017 | 0.025 | 0.011 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are support for Policies 1–3. The independent variables are the treatment indicator, an indicator (*Underestimator*) for underestimating the severity of the problem by more than 5 points on at least two of the three prior-belief items (non-take-up, understanding of the rules, and year-end corrections), and their interaction, $\alpha_3$ (H4 predicts $\alpha_3 > 0$). Controls are age, female, high education and higher income. The sample is restricted to the C1 and T arms of the analysis sample, because prior beliefs were elicited only in these arms; C1 is omitted. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A21.** Treatment effects on policy support, by prior underestimation: alternative measures

| | Policy 1: simpler system | Policy 2: basistoeslag | Policy 3: milder consequences |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Panel A: Underestimator (all 3 items)* | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.103 | −0.115 | 0.066 |
| | (0.131) | (0.151) | (0.138) |
| Underestimator (all 3 items) | −0.242 | −0.677** | 0.179 |
| | (0.244) | (0.277) | (0.254) |
| T × Underestimator (all 3 items) | 0.039 | 0.363 | −0.265 |
| | (0.342) | (0.385) | (0.365) |
| Constant | 6.202*** | 6.212*** | 6.267*** |
| | (0.231) | (0.279) | (0.245) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.013 | 0.031 | 0.009 |
| *Panel B: Mean gap* | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.244 | 0.040 | 0.190 |
| | (0.165) | (0.193) | (0.180) |
| Mean gap | −0.004 | −0.007 | 0.010 |
| | (0.007) | (0.008) | (0.008) |
| T × Mean gap | −0.011 | −0.006 | −0.015 |
| | (0.010) | (0.012) | (0.011) |
| Constant | 6.186*** | 6.182*** | 6.196*** |
| | (0.236) | (0.285) | (0.251) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.015 | 0.028 | 0.011 |
| *Panel C: Under-size* | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.147 | 0.074 | 0.407 |
| | (0.264) | (0.309) | (0.279) |
| Under-size | −0.005 | −0.004 | 0.003 |
| | (0.003) | (0.004) | (0.004) |
| T × Under-size | −0.001 | −0.002 | −0.008 |
| | (0.005) | (0.005) | (0.005) |
| Constant | 6.367*** | 6.300*** | 6.146*** |
| | (0.272) | (0.325) | (0.287) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.016 | 0.028 | 0.011 |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 1,457 | 1,457 | 1,457 |

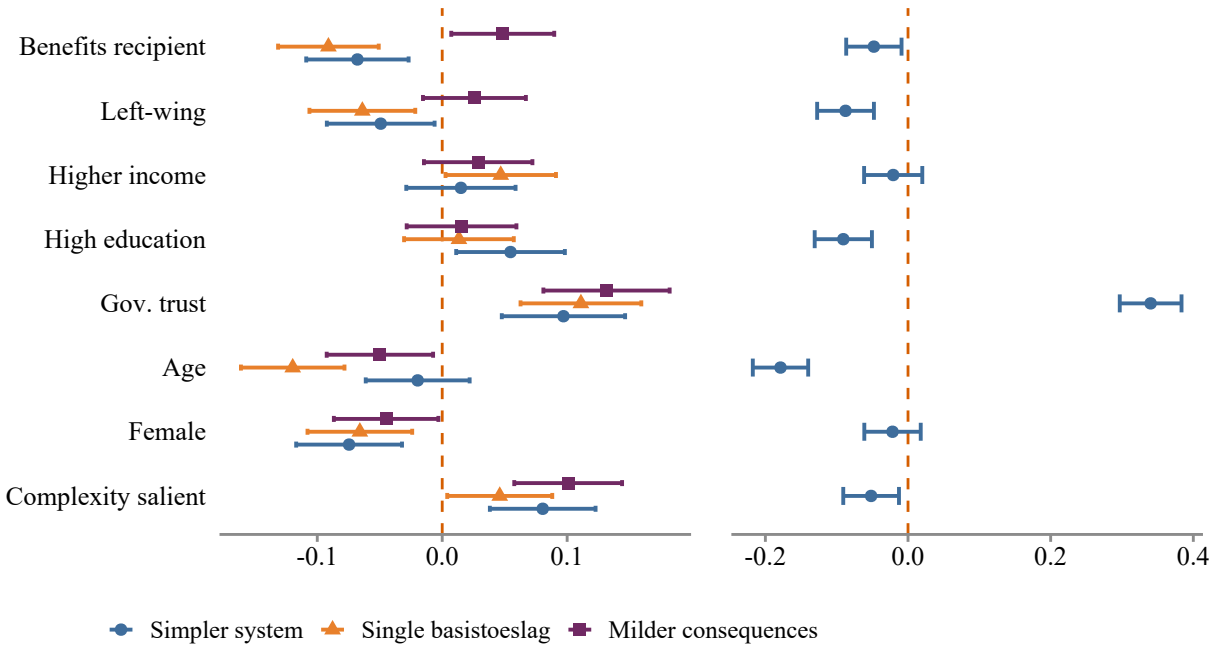
*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are support for Policies 1–3. The independent variables are the treatment indicator, a measure of prior underestimation, and their interaction, $\alpha_3$. The measure is: in Panel A, an indicator for underestimating the severity of the problem by more than 5 points on all three items; in Panel B, the mean signed gap between the prior and the true value across the three items, oriented so that positive values indicate underestimation; in Panel C, the sum of the positive (underestimating) gaps. Controls are age, female, high education and higher income. The sample is the C1 and T arms of the analysis sample; C1 is omitted. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

**Table A22.** Treatment effects on policy support, by prior accuracy

| | Policy 1: simpler system | Policy 2: basistoeslag | Policy 3: milder consequences |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Underestimators ($N = 961$)* | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.061 | −0.051 | −0.120 |
| | (0.153) | (0.172) | (0.155) |
| Constant | 6.046*** | 6.127*** | 6.472*** |
| | (0.282) | (0.339) | (0.293) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.006 | 0.030 | 0.014 |
| *Accurate ($N = 321$)* | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.329 | 0.286 | 0.468* |
| | (0.232) | (0.293) | (0.260) |
| Constant | 6.679*** | 6.557*** | 6.176*** |
| | (0.475) | (0.625) | (0.528) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.031 | 0.010 | −0.004 |
| *Overestimators ($N = 175$)* | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.061 | −0.459 | 0.020 |
| | (0.369) | (0.406) | (0.419) |
| Constant | 6.211*** | 5.575*** | 5.580*** |
| | (0.724) | (0.806) | (0.814) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.013 | 0.017 | 0.014 |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are support for Policies 1–3, estimated separately within each prior-accuracy group. The independent variable is the treatment indicator. Controls are age, female, high education and higher income. The sample is the C1 and T arms of the analysis sample; C1 is omitted. Overestimators overestimated the severity of the problem by more than 5 points on at least two of the three items, and accurate respondents are neither underestimators nor overestimators. The overestimator group is small, so those estimates are imprecise. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Figure A8.** Correlates of support for simplification (left) and of perceived harm (right)




*Notes.* Each point is a standardized OLS coefficient (all variables have mean 0 and unit variance) with 95% confidence intervals based on HC1 robust standard errors; the dashed vertical line marks zero. Both panels control for treatment arm and use the same covariates, shown once on the left. The **left** panel reports support for the three simplification policies (higher = more support). In the **right** panel the outcome asks whether the system's features make things better or worse for those entitled to support, from 0 (much worse) to 10 (much better), so a *negative* coefficient indicates the characteristic is associated with viewing the system as more harmful. $N = 2{,}212$.

**Table A23.** Correlates of policy support and posterior beliefs

| | Policy 1: simpler system (1) | Policy 2: basistoeslag (2) | Policy 3: milder consequences (3) | Complexity helps claimants (4) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Panel A: Full sample (extensive margin)* | | | | |
| Benefit recipient | $-0.320^{***}$ | $-0.504^{***}$ | $0.247^{**}$ | $-0.215^{**}$ |
| | (0.099) | (0.114) | (0.107) | (0.089) |
| Left-wing | $-0.266^{**}$ | $-0.405^{***}$ | 0.150 | $-0.450^{***}$ |
| | (0.119) | (0.137) | (0.123) | (0.104) |
| Higher income | 0.069 | $0.253^{**}$ | 0.143 | $-0.091$ |
| | (0.103) | (0.122) | (0.110) | (0.091) |
| High education | $0.258^{**}$ | 0.074 | 0.079 | $-0.407^{***}$ |
| | (0.105) | (0.124) | (0.114) | (0.092) |
| Trust in government | $0.089^{***}$ | $0.120^{***}$ | $0.131^{***}$ | $0.298^{***}$ |
| | (0.023) | (0.027) | (0.026) | (0.019) |
| Age | $-0.003$ | $-0.020^{***}$ | $-0.008^{**}$ | $-0.024^{***}$ |
| | (0.003) | (0.003) | (0.003) | (0.003) |
| Female | $-0.343^{***}$ | $-0.356^{***}$ | $-0.223^{**}$ | $-0.095$ |
| | (0.100) | (0.116) | (0.106) | (0.088) |
| Complexity salient | $0.375^{***}$ | $0.252^{**}$ | $0.507^{***}$ | $-0.229^{***}$ |
| | (0.101) | (0.117) | (0.111) | (0.088) |
| Constant | $5.750^{***}$ | $5.985^{***}$ | $5.268^{***}$ | $5.086^{***}$ |
| | (0.238) | (0.277) | (0.259) | (0.215) |
| Observations | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.036 | 0.052 | 0.040 | 0.167 |
| *Panel B: Benefit recipients only (intensity margin)* | | | | |
| Experienced complexity | $-0.006$ | $-0.009$ | 0.008 | $-0.010$ |
| | (0.010) | (0.012) | (0.011) | (0.009) |
| Left-wing | $-0.254^{*}$ | $-0.668^{***}$ | 0.149 | $-0.457^{***}$ |
| | (0.152) | (0.177) | (0.157) | (0.130) |
| Higher income | 0.012 | $0.299^{*}$ | 0.158 | $-0.090$ |
| | (0.136) | (0.165) | (0.141) | (0.119) |
| High education | $0.352^{**}$ | 0.214 | 0.203 | $-0.469^{***}$ |
| | (0.143) | (0.170) | (0.149) | (0.120) |
| Trust in government | $0.108^{***}$ | $0.117^{***}$ | $0.116^{***}$ | $0.315^{***}$ |
| | (0.031) | (0.037) | (0.034) | (0.026) |
| Age | $-0.008^{*}$ | $-0.026^{***}$ | $-0.012^{***}$ | $-0.025^{***}$ |
| | (0.004) | (0.005) | (0.004) | (0.004) |
| Female | $-0.345^{***}$ | $-0.390^{**}$ | $-0.144$ | $-0.133$ |
| | (0.133) | (0.157) | (0.138) | (0.115) |
| Complexity salient | $0.406^{***}$ | $0.321^{**}$ | $0.383^{***}$ | $-0.284^{**}$ |
| | (0.133) | (0.158) | (0.143) | (0.116) |
| Constant | $5.724^{***}$ | $5.897^{***}$ | $5.701^{***}$ | $5.061^{***}$ |
| | (0.349) | (0.410) | (0.361) | (0.310) |
| Observations | 1,347 | 1,347 | 1,347 | 1,347 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.034 | 0.054 | 0.030 | 0.181 |
| Treatment-arm controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are support for Policies 1–3 and Complexity helps claimants. The independent variables are the respondent characteristics shown. *Experienced complexity* is the sum, over all schemes the respondent has received, of each scheme's mean experienced-complexity score from IBO (2023). *Complexity salient* is an indicator for naming complexity (rules and paperwork too complicated, or too many different schemes and bodies) as one of the two biggest problems of the social security system, asked before the treatment. Treatment-arm controls are the treatment and elicitation indicators (coefficients not reported). The sample is the analysis sample in Panel A and the benefit recipients in it in Panel B. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A24.** Correlates of problems named at baseline

| | Complexity | Fraud | Too generous | Work does not pay | Too low |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) |
| Benefit recipient | $-0.045^{**}$ | $-0.020$ | $-0.047^{***}$ | $-0.018$ | $0.122^{***}$ |
| | (0.021) | (0.022) | (0.014) | (0.022) | (0.020) |
| Left-wing | $0.110^{***}$ | $-0.105^{***}$ | $-0.069^{***}$ | $-0.047^{*}$ | $0.069^{***}$ |
| | (0.024) | (0.024) | (0.012) | (0.025) | (0.024) |
| Higher income | 0.005 | $0.057^{***}$ | $0.038^{***}$ | $0.073^{***}$ | $-0.155^{***}$ |
| | (0.022) | (0.022) | (0.014) | (0.022) | (0.021) |
| High education | $0.074^{***}$ | $-0.035$ | $-0.007$ | $-0.025$ | $-0.067^{***}$ |
| | (0.022) | (0.022) | (0.014) | (0.023) | (0.021) |
| Trust in government | $0.022^{***}$ | 0.000 | 0.001 | $-0.024^{***}$ | $-0.004$ |
| | (0.004) | (0.004) | (0.003) | (0.004) | (0.004) |
| Age | $0.005^{***}$ | $0.003^{***}$ | $-0.002^{***}$ | $-0.005^{***}$ | $-0.003^{***}$ |
| | (0.001) | (0.001) | (0.000) | (0.001) | (0.001) |
| Female | 0.002 | $-0.018$ | $-0.029^{**}$ | 0.031 | $0.037^{*}$ |
| | (0.021) | (0.021) | (0.013) | (0.021) | (0.020) |
| Constant | $0.185^{***}$ | $0.273^{***}$ | $0.218^{***}$ | $0.826^{***}$ | $0.537^{***}$ |
| | (0.047) | (0.048) | (0.029) | (0.048) | (0.047) |
| Observations | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.056 | 0.021 | 0.031 | 0.052 | 0.076 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions (linear probability models) where the dependent variables are indicators for selecting a given item as one of the two biggest problems of the social security system: complexity (column 1, as in Complexity salient), fraud and misuse (column 2), benefits too generous (column 3), work does not pay (column 4), and benefits too low (column 5). The independent variables are the respondent characteristics shown. The dependent variables are measured before the treatment, so no treatment-arm indicators are included. The sample is the analysis sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A25.** Correlates of prior underestimation

| | Underestimator (all 3 items) (1) | Absolute gap (accuracy) (2) | Mean gap (signed) (3) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Complexity salient | −0.033 | −1.278** | −0.782 |
| | (0.020) | (0.513) | (0.689) |
| Left-wing | 0.034 | 0.546 | 0.606 |
| | (0.024) | (0.631) | (0.793) |
| Higher income | 0.010 | 0.348 | −0.236 |
| | (0.021) | (0.535) | (0.703) |
| High education | 0.026 | 0.038 | 0.644 |
| | (0.022) | (0.553) | (0.724) |
| Benefit recipient | 0.020 | −0.288 | 0.528 |
| | (0.020) | (0.513) | (0.682) |
| Trust in government | 0.012*** | 0.054 | 0.907*** |
| | (0.004) | (0.104) | (0.136) |
| Age | 0.002*** | 0.077*** | 0.105*** |
| | (0.001) | (0.016) | (0.020) |
| Female | 0.028 | −0.529 | 0.369 |
| | (0.021) | (0.492) | (0.656) |
| Constant | −0.028 | 19.318*** | 1.572 |
| | (0.045) | (1.165) | (1.515) |
| Observations | 1,457 | 1,457 | 1,457 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.013 | 0.016 | 0.044 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are Underestimator (all 3 items) (column 1, a linear probability model), the mean absolute gap between the priors and the true values across the three items (column 2), and the mean gap (column 3). The independent variables are the respondent characteristics shown. The sample is the C1 and T arms of the analysis sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A26.** Treatment effects on policy support, by respondent characteristic

| Moderator (H): | (1) Left-wing | (2) Benefit recipient | (3) Higher income | (4) High education | (5) Fraud salient | (6) Complexity salient |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Panel A. Policy 1: simpler system* | | | | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.103 | 0.483*** | 0.278 | 0.366** | 0.186 | 0.202 |
| | (0.134) | (0.174) | (0.170) | (0.153) | (0.147) | (0.186) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.032 | 0.183 | -0.054 | 0.169 | -0.010 | -0.018 |
| | (0.132) | (0.180) | (0.176) | (0.156) | (0.148) | (0.186) |
| H | -0.307 | -0.084 | 0.091 | 0.567*** | -0.366** | 0.364** |
| | (0.198) | (0.165) | (0.166) | (0.164) | (0.170) | (0.166) |
| T × H | 0.252 | -0.525** | -0.238 | -0.514** | -0.017 | -0.053 |
| | (0.274) | (0.232) | (0.233) | (0.234) | (0.240) | (0.238) |
| C1 × H | -0.003 | -0.250 | 0.175 | -0.346 | 0.114 | 0.086 |
| | (0.292) | (0.237) | (0.235) | (0.238) | (0.243) | (0.239) |
| Constant | 5.836*** | 5.678*** | 5.819*** | 5.712*** | 5.920*** | 5.761*** |
| | (0.237) | (0.252) | (0.250) | (0.245) | (0.244) | (0.253) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.030 | 0.032 | 0.031 | 0.032 | 0.035 | 0.036 |
| *Panel B. Policy 2: basistoeslag* | | | | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.080 | 0.182 | 0.096 | 0.143 | 0.013 | 0.059 |
| | (0.155) | (0.196) | (0.204) | (0.178) | (0.177) | (0.214) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.049 | 0.157 | 0.077 | 0.062 | 0.119 | 0.131 |
| | (0.155) | (0.203) | (0.202) | (0.181) | (0.172) | (0.217) |
| H | -0.639*** | -0.503** | 0.163 | 0.001 | -0.649*** | 0.175 |
| | (0.237) | (0.196) | (0.199) | (0.203) | (0.201) | (0.199) |
| T × H | 0.299 | -0.052 | 0.105 | 0.015 | 0.400 | 0.172 |
| | (0.331) | (0.271) | (0.274) | (0.278) | (0.281) | (0.278) |
| C1 × H | 0.489 | 0.012 | 0.174 | 0.259 | 0.131 | 0.059 |
| | (0.329) | (0.274) | (0.274) | (0.277) | (0.283) | (0.280) |
| Constant | 6.097*** | 6.028*** | 6.078*** | 6.072*** | 6.214*** | 6.025*** |
| | (0.277) | (0.295) | (0.288) | (0.283) | (0.282) | (0.296) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.051 | 0.050 | 0.050 | 0.050 | 0.057 | 0.051 |
| *Panel C. Policy 3: milder consequences* | | | | | | |
| Treatment (T) | 0.178 | 0.181 | -0.079 | 0.110 | 0.380** | -0.116 |
| | (0.146) | (0.197) | (0.190) | (0.164) | (0.152) | (0.204) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.168 | 0.189 | 0.021 | 0.177 | 0.186 | 0.136 |
| | (0.149) | (0.205) | (0.190) | (0.169) | (0.157) | (0.211) |
| H | 0.282 | 0.266 | -0.080 | 0.113 | -0.531*** | 0.337* |
| | (0.215) | (0.187) | (0.188) | (0.191) | (0.196) | (0.192) |
| T × H | -0.051 | -0.023 | 0.492* | 0.143 | -0.462* | 0.520** |
| | (0.294) | (0.257) | (0.253) | (0.257) | (0.264) | (0.258) |
| C1 × H | -0.178 | -0.104 | 0.201 | -0.130 | -0.152 | -0.014 |
| | (0.302) | (0.265) | (0.260) | (0.263) | (0.273) | (0.266) |
| Constant | 5.347*** | 5.338*** | 5.470*** | 5.367*** | 5.487*** | 5.348*** |
| | (0.263) | (0.280) | (0.272) | (0.266) | (0.265) | (0.279) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.030 | 0.030 | 0.032 | 0.030 | 0.051 | 0.042 |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Observations | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 | 2,212 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are support for Policies 1–3. The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators, a moderator (H), and the interactions of both indicators with H; C0 is omitted. *Fraud salient* is an indicator for naming fraud and misuse as one of the two biggest problems of the social security system, asked before the treatment. Controls are age, female, high education, higher income, left-wing, trust in government and benefit recipient, excluding the moderator of the column. The sample is the analysis sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A27.** Treatment effect on the quantitative posterior belief, by benefit receipt

| | Benefit corrections (0–100) | |
|---|---|---|
| | Non-recipients | Recipients |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Treatment (T) | 6.727*** | 5.559*** |
| | (1.656) | (1.352) |
| Constant | 59.362*** | 61.269*** |
| | (3.725) | (3.280) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.077 | 0.072 |
| Observations | 570 | 887 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is Benefit corrections. Zorgtoeslag corrections were not part of the information treatment, so this measure tests whether the correction generalises. The independent variable is the treatment indicator. Controls are age, female, high education, higher income, left-wing and trust in government. The sample is the C1 and T arms of the analysis sample, split by benefit receipt; C1 is omitted. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A28.** Treatment effects on support for a simpler system: all characteristics jointly

| | Main effect (1) | × T (2) | × C1 (3) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Benefit recipient | -0.063 | -0.611** | -0.222 |
| | (0.169) | (0.240) | (0.244) |
| Age | 0.002 | -0.003 | -0.005 |
| | (0.005) | (0.007) | (0.007) |
| Female | -0.245 | -0.075 | -0.224 |
| | (0.168) | (0.243) | (0.243) |
| High education | 0.604*** | -0.504** | -0.474* |
| | (0.173) | (0.252) | (0.257) |
| Higher income | 0.038 | -0.201 | 0.240 |
| | (0.175) | (0.249) | (0.253) |
| Left-wing | -0.422** | 0.442 | 0.141 |
| | (0.201) | (0.282) | (0.297) |
| Trust in government | 0.120*** | -0.058 | -0.006 |
| | (0.039) | (0.057) | (0.056) |
| Arm (T or C1) | | 1.184** | 0.599 |
| | | (0.573) | (0.540) |
| Constant | 5.309*** | | |
| | (0.400) | | |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | | 0.033 | |
| Observations | | 2,212 | |

*Notes:* The table reports a single OLS regression where the dependent variable is support for Policy 1. The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators, the respondent characteristics shown, and the interactions of both indicators with all characteristics; C0 is omitted. Column (1) reports the main effects of the characteristics, and columns (2) and (3) their interactions with T and C1. The arm coefficients are the effects for a respondent with all characteristics equal to zero and are not meaningful on their own. The sample is the analysis sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A29.** Treatment effects on beliefs and policy support, by experienced complexity

| | Complexity helps claimants (1) | Policy 1: simpler system (2) |
|---|---|---|
| Treatment (T) | -0.620** | 0.134 |
| | (0.251) | (0.284) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.112 | 0.002 |
| | (0.260) | (0.286) |
| Experienced complexity | -0.000 | 0.000 |
| | (0.015) | (0.016) |
| T × Experienced complexity | -0.008 | -0.016 |
| | (0.020) | (0.024) |
| C1 × Experienced complexity | -0.019 | -0.006 |
| | (0.021) | (0.024) |
| Constant | 4.918*** | 5.731*** |
| | (0.337) | (0.372) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.177 | 0.027 |
| Observations | 1,347 | 1,347 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are Complexity helps claimants (column 1) and support for Policy 1 (column 2). The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators, experienced complexity, and their interactions; C0 is omitted. The coefficients on T and C1 are the effects at zero experienced complexity, which lies outside the range for recipients. Controls are age, female, high education, higher income, left-wing and trust in government. The sample is the benefit recipients in the analysis sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

**Table A30.** Treatment effects on support for a simpler system, by benefit receipt: excluding possible demand effects

| | Full sample | | Excl. guessed purpose | | Excl. felt steered | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Non-recipients | Recipients | Non-recipients | Recipients | Non-recipients | Recipients |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) | (6) |
| Treatment (T) | 0.480*** | -0.039 | 0.515*** | -0.005 | 0.409** | 0.027 |
| | (0.174) | (0.155) | (0.183) | (0.161) | (0.189) | (0.164) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.204 | -0.062 | 0.243 | -0.009 | 0.174 | -0.064 |
| | (0.181) | (0.155) | (0.188) | (0.163) | (0.191) | (0.165) |
| Constant | 5.530*** | 5.712*** | 5.576*** | 5.650*** | 5.271*** | 5.677*** |
| | (0.332) | (0.317) | (0.352) | (0.330) | (0.354) | (0.335) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.021 | 0.029 | 0.022 | 0.029 | 0.024 | 0.034 |
| Observations | 865 | 1,347 | 794 | 1,231 | 756 | 1,190 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is support for Policy 1. The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators; C0 is omitted. Controls are age, female, high education, higher income, left-wing and trust in government. The sample is the analysis sample, split by benefit receipt; columns (3) and (4) exclude respondents who guessed the purpose of the study (strict coding), and columns (5) and (6) those who felt steered. Both variables are measured after the treatment, so columns (3)–(6) are a robustness check only. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A31.** Correlates of data quality

| | Passed attention check (1) | Included in analysis sample (2) |
|---|---|---|
| Benefit recipient | 0.061*** | 0.067*** |
| | (0.015) | (0.015) |
| Age | 0.007*** | 0.008*** |
| | (0.000) | (0.000) |
| Female | 0.064*** | 0.070*** |
| | (0.014) | (0.014) |
| High education | 0.021 | 0.009 |
| | (0.015) | (0.015) |
| Higher income | 0.039*** | 0.048*** |
| | (0.015) | (0.015) |
| Left-wing | 0.011 | 0.022 |
| | (0.016) | (0.017) |
| Trust in government | -0.017*** | -0.020*** |
| | (0.003) | (0.003) |
| Treatment (T) | -0.015 | -0.018 |
| | (0.016) | (0.017) |
| Elicitation (C1) | -0.007 | -0.010 |
| | (0.017) | (0.017) |
| Constant | 0.465*** | 0.410*** |
| | (0.035) | (0.035) |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.132 | 0.161 |
| Observations | 2,728 | 2,728 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions (linear probability models) where the dependent variables are indicators for passing the instructed attention check (column 1) and for being included in the analysis sample (column 2). The independent variables are the respondent characteristics and arm indicators shown; C0 is omitted. The sample is all respondents who completed the survey. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A32.** Correlates of arguments in open-ended answers

| | Benefit recipient | Age | Female | High education | Higher income | Left-wing | Trust in government | Constant | Treatment-arm controls | Adjusted $R^2$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Own stake and risks of reform* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Reform would cut support | 0.034*** | 0.000 | 0.019** | 0.006 | -0.000 | 0.019* | -0.003* | 0.005 | ✓ | 0.009 |
| | (0.009) | (0.000) | (0.009) | (0.010) | (0.011) | (0.012) | (0.002) | (0.021) | | |
| Loss of targeting | 0.030*** | 0.001* | 0.037*** | -0.006 | 0.011 | 0.014 | 0.006*** | -0.026 | ✓ | 0.009 |
| | (0.011) | (0.000) | (0.011) | (0.012) | (0.012) | (0.014) | (0.002) | (0.021) | | |
| Risk of change | 0.016 | 0.001* | -0.000 | 0.006 | -0.015 | -0.000 | -0.002 | 0.019 | ✓ | 0.003 |
| | (0.010) | (0.000) | (0.010) | (0.011) | (0.011) | (0.012) | (0.002) | (0.023) | | |
| Own situation | 0.045*** | -0.000 | 0.022** | -0.016 | -0.017 | 0.011 | -0.004* | 0.086*** | ✓ | 0.018 |
| | (0.010) | (0.000) | (0.011) | (0.012) | (0.012) | (0.013) | (0.002) | (0.025) | | |
| *Complexity and access* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Complexity and bureaucracy | 0.055*** | 0.003*** | -0.040** | 0.072*** | 0.046** | 0.043* | -0.001 | 0.011 | ✓ | 0.031 |
| | (0.019) | (0.001) | (0.019) | (0.021) | (0.020) | (0.023) | (0.004) | (0.044) | | |
| Errors and corrections | 0.029*** | -0.000 | 0.019** | -0.005 | 0.011 | -0.002 | -0.001 | 0.017 | ✓ | 0.007 |
| | (0.008) | (0.000) | (0.008) | (0.009) | (0.009) | (0.009) | (0.002) | (0.016) | | |
| Access and take-up | 0.007 | -0.000 | 0.010 | 0.017 | 0.013 | 0.038** | 0.008*** | 0.007 | ✓ | 0.016 |
| | (0.012) | (0.000) | (0.013) | (0.014) | (0.013) | (0.016) | (0.002) | (0.029) | | |
| *Generosity and deservingness* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Fraud and misuse | -0.045*** | 0.001*** | 0.004 | 0.002 | 0.036*** | -0.020 | -0.010*** | 0.090*** | ✓ | 0.022 |
| | (0.013) | (0.000) | (0.012) | (0.012) | (0.013) | (0.013) | (0.002) | (0.028) | | |
| Fraud from reform | -0.002 | 0.000*** | 0.007 | 0.016** | 0.002 | -0.009 | -0.001 | -0.004 | ✓ | 0.003 |
| | (0.006) | (0.000) | (0.006) | (0.006) | (0.006) | (0.006) | (0.001) | (0.013) | | |
| Too generous | -0.025*** | 0.000 | 0.013 | -0.004 | 0.022** | -0.019** | -0.010*** | 0.084*** | ✓ | 0.023 |
| | (0.010) | (0.000) | (0.009) | (0.009) | (0.010) | (0.008) | (0.002) | (0.020) | | |
| Work should pay | -0.019 | -0.000 | 0.012 | -0.002 | 0.046*** | -0.021* | -0.007*** | 0.105*** | ✓ | 0.014 |
| | (0.012) | (0.000) | (0.011) | (0.012) | (0.012) | (0.011) | (0.002) | (0.026) | | |
| Support too low | 0.020** | -0.000 | 0.030*** | 0.003 | -0.012 | 0.011 | -0.008*** | 0.083*** | ✓ | 0.017 |
| | (0.009) | (0.000) | (0.010) | (0.010) | (0.010) | (0.012) | (0.002) | (0.022) | | |
| *Other* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Cost and efficiency | 0.003 | 0.001*** | -0.028*** | 0.027*** | 0.012 | -0.006 | -0.003* | 0.009 | ✓ | 0.016 |
| | (0.008) | (0.000) | (0.008) | (0.009) | (0.008) | (0.009) | (0.001) | (0.021) | | |
| Distrust of government | 0.012** | 0.000* | -0.011* | 0.007 | -0.004 | 0.008 | -0.008*** | 0.043*** | ✓ | 0.021 |
| | (0.006) | (0.000) | (0.007) | (0.007) | (0.006) | (0.008) | (0.002) | (0.016) | | |
| Immigration | -0.001 | 0.000 | -0.000 | 0.000 | 0.002 | -0.011*** | -0.005*** | 0.038*** | ✓ | 0.016 |
| | (0.005) | (0.000) | (0.005) | (0.004) | (0.005) | (0.002) | (0.001) | (0.012) | | |
| No substantive answer | -0.105*** | -0.004*** | -0.036* | -0.064*** | -0.082*** | -0.014 | 0.021*** | 0.572*** | ✓ | 0.048 |
| | (0.021) | (0.001) | (0.020) | (0.021) | (0.021) | (0.023) | (0.004) | (0.048) | | |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions (linear probability models), one per row, where the dependent variable equals 1 if the respondent's open-ended answer on the reasons for supporting or opposing simplification makes the given argument (LLM-coded; an answer can make several arguments). The independent variables are the respondent characteristics shown and the treatment-arm controls (coefficients not reported); C0 is omitted. The sample is the analysis sample, excluding 59 very short answers that the LLM did not classify (2,153 observations). Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A33.** Correlates of arguments in open-ended answers: respondents with a substantive answer

| | Benefit recipient | Age | Female | High education | Higher income | Left-wing | Trust in government | Constant | Treatment-arm controls | Adjusted $R^2$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Own stake and risks of reform* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Reform would cut support | 0.039*** | 0.000 | 0.024* | 0.003 | -0.006 | 0.024 | -0.003 | 0.028 | ✓ | 0.007 |
| | (0.013) | (0.000) | (0.013) | (0.015) | (0.015) | (0.016) | (0.002) | (0.031) | | |
| Own situation | 0.048*** | -0.001 | 0.028* | -0.033** | -0.033** | 0.012 | -0.003 | 0.160*** | ✓ | 0.025 |
| | (0.015) | (0.000) | (0.015) | (0.016) | (0.017) | (0.019) | (0.003) | (0.038) | | |
| *Complexity and access* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Complexity and bureaucracy | 0.024 | 0.002*** | -0.074*** | 0.065** | 0.025 | 0.047 | 0.010** | 0.146** | ✓ | 0.029 |
| | (0.026) | (0.001) | (0.025) | (0.027) | (0.027) | (0.030) | (0.005) | (0.062) | | |

*Notes:* The table repeats selected regressions from Table A32 on the respondents whose open-ended answer was coded as substantive (1,521 observations), that is, excluding answers coded as *No substantive answer*. Each row is an OLS regression (linear probability model) where the dependent variable equals 1 if the respondent's open-ended answer makes the given argument (LLM-coded). The independent variables are the respondent characteristics shown and the treatment-arm controls (coefficients not reported); C0 is omitted. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A34.** Treatment effects on beliefs and policy support, by education

| | Complexity helps claimants | | Policy 1: simpler system | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Low education | High education | Low education | High education |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| Treatment (T) | -0.677*** | -0.428*** | 0.369** | -0.152 |
| | (0.133) | (0.166) | (0.153) | (0.177) |
| Elicitation (C1) | -0.143 | -0.011 | 0.173 | -0.169 |
| | (0.133) | (0.164) | (0.156) | (0.179) |
| Constant | 4.763*** | 4.938*** | 6.330*** | 5.303*** |
| | (0.275) | (0.335) | (0.305) | (0.387) |
| $p$-value: T = C1 | <0.001 | 0.014 | 0.208 | 0.930 |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.145 | 0.201 | 0.037 | 0.019 |
| Observations | 1,339 | 873 | 1,339 | 873 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variables are Complexity helps claimants (columns 1 and 2) and support for Policy 1 (columns 3 and 4). The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators; C0 is omitted. Controls are age, female, higher income, left-wing, trust in government and benefit recipient. The sample is the analysis sample, split by education. The $p$-value is from a Wald test that the coefficients on T and C1 are equal. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A35.** Treatment effect on the quantitative posterior belief, by education

| | Benefit corrections (0–100) | |
|---|---|---|
| | Low education | High education |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Treatment (T) | 4.682*** | 8.301*** |
| | (1.345) | (1.637) |
| Constant | 65.234*** | 50.621*** |
| | (3.154) | (4.366) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.069 | 0.089 |
| Observations | 886 | 571 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is Benefit corrections. The independent variable is the treatment indicator. Controls are age, female, higher income, left-wing, trust in government and benefit recipient. The sample is the C1 and T arms of the analysis sample, split by education; C1 is omitted. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. $^{*}$ $p < 0.10$, $^{**}$ $p < 0.05$, $^{***}$ $p < 0.01$.

**Table A36.** Treatment effects on support for a simpler system, by education: excluding possible demand effects

| | Full sample | | Excl. guessed purpose | | Excl. felt steered | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Low education (1) | High education (2) | Low education (3) | High education (4) | Low education (5) | High education (6) |
| Treatment (T) | 0.369** | -0.152 | 0.402** | -0.123 | 0.336** | -0.064 |
| | (0.153) | (0.177) | (0.160) | (0.187) | (0.163) | (0.188) |
| Elicitation (C1) | 0.173 | -0.169 | 0.229 | -0.130 | 0.142 | -0.167 |
| | (0.156) | (0.179) | (0.163) | (0.185) | (0.166) | (0.188) |
| Constant | 6.330*** | 5.303*** | 6.299*** | 5.253*** | 6.303*** | 5.039*** |
| | (0.305) | (0.387) | (0.319) | (0.409) | (0.326) | (0.405) |
| Controls | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.037 | 0.019 | 0.032 | 0.018 | 0.039 | 0.023 |
| Observations | 1,339 | 873 | 1,224 | 801 | 1,166 | 780 |

*Notes:* The table reports OLS regressions where the dependent variable is support for Policy 1. The independent variables are the treatment and elicitation indicators; C0 is omitted. Controls are age, female, higher income, left-wing, trust in government and benefit recipient. The sample is the analysis sample, split by education; columns (3) and (4) exclude respondents who guessed the purpose of the study (strict coding), and columns (5) and (6) those who felt steered. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

## B. Experimental Instructions

This appendix reproduces the instructions and questions of the two experiments as respondents saw them. Each block headed in small capitals is one screen. Text in italics and square brackets was not shown to respondents: it describes the survey flow, the answer format, or differences between treatments. Timers, embedded data, and other technical elements of the Qualtrics files are omitted.

### B.1. Spectator experiment

The spectator experiment was programmed in Qualtrics and fielded on Prolific, in English. After the general instructions, each spectator was randomly assigned to one of three treatments (T1, T2, T3). Below we show the T1 version in full. Where T2 or T3 differ, we give the alternative text in square brackets, and we show the treatment-specific figures separately. In the instructions the Complex system is called *System A* and the Simple system *System B*. System A was always shown first.

| | Form under System A | Who is compensated under System A |
|---|---|---|
| T1 | 7 minutes | every worker whose output is not fully registered (7 Yellow, 1 Green) |
| T2 | 2 minutes | every worker whose output is not fully registered (7 Yellow, 1 Green) |
| T3 | 7 minutes | all but one: the form is unavailable to 1 Yellow worker (6 Yellow, 2 Green) |

In all treatments, System B compensates the 8 Yellow workers automatically, and both systems compensate 8 of the 12 workers with the same amount.

*Introduction and consent*

INTRODUCTION

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Thank you for participating in this study.
This is a study conducted by researchers at the University of Amsterdam. All data collected in this study are for research purposes only.
The study should last approximately 16 minutes.
For your participation, you will be paid a participation fee of £3.50. You might also earn an additional bonus of £0.25. This bonus will be explained to you later. Due to organisational issues, we need some time to transfer the bonus. You will receive this payment within the next 4 weeks. We will try to be as fast as possible.

This study must be completed on a desktop computer, laptop, or tablet, as it includes figures and tables that need a larger screen to read properly. The type of device you use is recorded, so please make sure you are using one of these before you continue.

## CONSENT

**Confidentiality**

Note that your identity will remain anonymous throughout the study. We will only use your Prolific ID to provide payment. The data may be published in aggregate form in scientific articles or academic presentations. Your personal identity will not be revealed.

Your participation is voluntary. You may withdraw at any time during the study. However, if you withdraw, you will not receive any money.

Please indicate, in the box below, that you are at least 18 years old and have read and understood this consent form, and that you agree to participate in this study.

- ◯ I agree to participate in this study, I am at least 18 years of age and have read the consent form.
- ◯ I do not want to participate in this study. *[ends the survey]*

## NO USE OF AI TOOLS

One more important point before we begin. Your honest and thoughtful answers are essential to the success of our research. We study how real people think and feel, and the value of this work depends entirely on the authenticity of your answers.

Therefore, please do not use AI tools to generate or support your answers. This undermines the integrity of our research.

All submissions are carefully reviewed to ensure quality. If we detect the use of AI tools, we consider this a violation of Prolific's policy, and we may report this and cancel participation.

We rely on your cooperation and thank you for your contribution to this important research! Please confirm below that you understand this.

- ◯ I will not use AI tools.
- ◯ I do not want to participate in this study. *[ends the survey]*

## PLEDGE TO READ

In what follows, we will ask you to make decisions that can affect real people.

Because these decisions have real consequences, it is important that you understand the situation before you make them. Please read all the instructions that follow carefully. Afterwards, a short quiz will check your understanding.

◯ I understand that I need to read the instructions carefully in order to make an informed decision, and I will do so.

*[Next screen: Prolific ID, filled in automatically.]*

ATTENTION CHECK

---

This study should take approximately 16 minutes to complete. It is important that you take the time to read all instructions and that you read questions carefully before you answer them. Previous research has found that some people do not take the time to read everything that is displayed. Below, there are two questions. To show that you read our questions carefully, please choose both 'Monday' and 'Tuesday' as your answer in the first question and type 'darts' into the 'Other' field of the second question.

*What are your preferred days to do sports? (Click all that apply)*

☐ Monday
☐ Tuesday
☐ Wednesday
☐ Thursday
☐ Friday
☐ Saturday
☐ Sunday

*What is your favourite sport?*

◯ Football
◯ Tennis
◯ Basketball
◯ Volleyball
◯ Golf
◯ Wrestling
◯ Other: _____

*General instructions (all treatments)*

INSTRUCTIONS 1 OF 6

---

We will now move to the main part of the study.

It is very important that you read the information that will follow, as in this study you will make a choice that can affect real people.

These people are recruited by us to complete tasks individually, in exchange for a payment. From now on, we will call these people "workers".

On the next pages, you will learn about the workers' situation and the choice you will be asked to make.

INSTRUCTIONS 2 OF 6

---

Workers are randomly assigned to be Yellow or Green.
Most workers are assigned to be Yellow.
Both types work on exactly the same set of tasks for 15 minutes.

INSTRUCTIONS 3 OF 6

---

Workers are paid for their work: the more tasks they complete, the more they earn.
However, for some workers, part of their output is not registered; it does not count towards their pay.
They work for the full duration of 15 minutes, but after minute 8 their completed tasks are no longer registered. They are only paid for the tasks registered in the first 8 minutes.
Because of that, workers whose output is not fully registered are, on average, paid less than workers whose output is fully registered.

INSTRUCTIONS 4 OF 6

---

Workers assigned to Yellow are much more likely to have their output not fully registered than workers assigned to Green. Note however, as said before, workers have no control over the colour they are assigned.
Aside from being more likely for workers assigned to Yellow, whether part of a worker's output goes unregistered is random and unrelated to their effort or ability.
Workers are told that their completed output might not be fully registered, due to a random process outside their control. They are not told how likely this is, whether it differs between colours, or which colour they themselves are. As a result, during the session a worker cannot know whether their own output is fully registered.

INSTRUCTIONS 5 OF 6

---

**Compensation**
We have set aside funds to give additional compensation to some workers.
This compensation is added on top of their other earnings.
The compensation is equal to the difference between the average earnings of workers whose output is fully registered and those whose output is not fully registered.

There is more than one way to decide which workers actually receive this compensation. We call each of these a compensation system.

INSTRUCTIONS 6 OF 6

---

Your task is to decide on a compensation system for a subset of 12 workers.
1 in 30 respondents of this study will be selected at random and their choice will be implemented for 12 real workers.
Whether you are selected does not depend on which system you choose, so please choose the system you genuinely think is best. There is no right and wrong answer.
Your decision is anonymous and not observed by other respondents. Workers know that a decision of another person may affect their payment, but they are not told the details, such as which systems are possible, how the decision is made, or what other workers receive. Each worker receives their payments without being told exactly how the amount was determined.
On the next page, you will learn more about the workers you are deciding for.

*Treatment-specific instructions*

*[Random assignment to T1, T2, or T3.]*

THE 12 WORKERS

---

You will be deciding which compensation system to implement for 12 workers. To help you picture them, we represent each worker below with a figure. Keep in mind that these figures stand for real people.
Each figure's colour and legs tell you about that worker:

- Colour shows the worker's assigned colour: Yellow or Green.
- Grey legs mean worker's output is not fully registered; full colour means their output is fully registered.

As mentioned, workers whose output is not fully registered (shown with grey legs) earn, on average, less than other workers.



*[T1 and T2. T3 is shown in Figure B3.]*

As you can see, among these 12 workers, there are 8 workers assigned to Yellow and 4 workers assigned to Green.
7 out of 8 workers assigned to Yellow have part of their output unregistered.
1 out of 4 workers assigned to Green has part of their output unregistered. *[T3: 2 out of 4 workers assigned to Green have part of their output unregistered.]*

## TWO COMPENSATION SYSTEMS

You can choose between two different compensation systems for these 12 workers. These systems differ in who is paid and what is required from the worker to access the compensation.

However, both systems pay the same amount to each compensated worker. Both systems also compensate 8 of the 12 workers. That means they have the same total budget.

On the next pages, you will learn more about these two systems.

## DESCRIPTION OF THE SYSTEMS

| System A | System B |
|---|---|
| **Who is paid the compensation** | **Who is paid the compensation** |
| Every worker whose output is not fully registered. *[T3: . . . , except for one.]* | Every worker assigned to Yellow. |
| **Who is not paid the compensation** | **Who is not paid the compensation** |
| Workers whose output is fully registered. *[T3: . . . and one worker whose output is not fully registered.]* | Workers assigned to Green. |
| **What is required** | **What is required** |
| Workers whose output is not fully registered go through a required verification step: completing a form that reports details of their working session.<br>They complete it after the end of their working session. It takes about 7 minutes *[T2: 2 minutes]*. The time spent on the form is not paid; it is simply required in order to receive the compensation.<br>*[T3 only: However, the form is unavailable to 1 worker assigned to Yellow whose output is not fully registered. This worker does not fill in the form and so does not receive the compensation. This is outside the worker's control: they do not cause it and cannot prevent it.]*<br>All of them *[T3: All other workers whose output is not fully registered]* complete the form and receive the compensation. | Nothing. Every worker assigned to Yellow receives the compensation automatically. There is no form to complete and nothing to report. Workers who receive the compensation spend no extra time after their working session. |

**Remember: the compensation amount is identical under both systems, and each compensates 8 of the 12 workers!**

WHAT EACH SYSTEM MEANS FOR THE 12 WORKERS

We will show you what each system would mean for these 12 workers.
For each system, a figure shows which workers receive the compensation and which complete the form, and a table summarises the total time each type of worker spends and what they are paid.


beneath a worker means that worker completes the verification form, which takes **7 minutes**.


beneath a worker means that worker receives the compensation.

*[T2: "…which takes **2 minutes**."]*

ILLUSTRATION OF THE TWO SYSTEMS

Remember:

- Colour shows the worker's assigned colour: Yellow or Green.
- Grey legs mean worker's output is not fully registered; full colour means their output is fully registered.
- Workers whose output is not fully registered end up with lower task earnings than workers whose output is fully registered.

*[Followed by the figures and tables in Figure B1 (T1), Figure B2 (T2), or Figure B3 (T3).]*

*Comprehension quiz*

BEFORE THE QUIZ

Before you make your decisions, we ask you to take a short quiz to check your understanding of the situation. For each of several statements, you will indicate whether it is true or false. If you answer all of them correctly, you will receive a bonus payment of £0.25.
Do you want to read the instructions again before you start the quiz?

◯ Yes
◯ No

*[If "Yes": one screen that repeats all treatment-specific instructions and figures above, introduced by "Here are the instructions again. Take a moment to review, then continue to the quiz."]*

QUIZ

Please indicate whether each of the following statements is true or false. If you answer any of them incorrectly, you will be shown a short clarification afterwards. As a reminder, the two systems are shown below.

*[The System A and System B figures are shown here (as on the choice screen, Figure B4). Each statement is answered True or False. Correct answers are given in the table below and were not shown.]*

| | Statement | T1, T2 | T3 |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Whether part of a worker's output is (not) fully registered depends on how hard they work. | False | False |
| 2 | All workers work for the full 15 minutes, whether or not part of their output is unregistered. | True | True |
| 3 | During the session, workers can tell whether part of their own output is not being registered. | False | False |
| 4 | Under System A (verification form required), every worker whose output is not fully registered receives the compensation. | True | False |
| 5 | Under System A (verification form required), workers whose output is fully registered do not receive the compensation. | True | True |
| 6 | Under System B (no form, automatic), the compensation goes to all workers assigned to Yellow. | True | True |
| 7 | Under System B (no form, automatic), all workers whose output is not fully registered receive the compensation. | False | False |
| 8 | Under System A, all workers whose output is not fully registered fill in the verification form, which takes about 7 minutes *[T2: 2 minutes]*. *[T3 adds: "..., except one worker to whom the form is unavailable."]* | True | True |

CLARIFICATIONS

*[Shown only for statements answered incorrectly. Each clarification repeats the statement, followed by:]*

1. This is false. Whether part of a worker's output is registered does not depend on how hard they work, or on any other behaviour. It is not something the worker can influence.
2. This is true. Every worker works the full 15 minutes, regardless of whether part of their output ends up unregistered.
3. This is false. Workers do not know during the session that part of their output is not being registered. They are told it might happen, but not whether it is actually happening to them.
4. *[T1, T2]* This is true. Under System A, every worker whose output is not fully registered fills in the verification form and receives the compensation.
   *[T3]* This is false. Under System A, the verification form is unavailable to one worker whose output is not fully registered, so they do not receive the compensation. All the other such workers fill in the form and receive the compensation.

5. This is true. Under System A, the compensation goes *[T3: can go]* only to workers whose output is not fully registered. Workers whose output is fully registered do not receive it.
6. This is true. Under System B, the compensation goes automatically to all workers assigned to Yellow, with no form required.
7. This is false. Under System B, the compensation is based on colour. A worker whose output is not fully registered but who is assigned to Green does not receive it.
8. This is true. Under System A, all workers whose output is not fully registered fill in the verification form, which takes about 7 minutes *[T2: 2 minutes; T3 adds: ", except one worker to whom the form is unavailable"]*.

*Choice*

CHOICE

---

We now ask you to choose which compensation system to implement for these 12 workers.
Your decision is anonymous and not observed by other respondents. As mentioned, workers know that another person's decision may affect their payment, but they are not told the details, such as which systems are possible, or how the decision is made, or what other workers receive. They simply do what is asked of them (complete their tasks and, where required, fill in a form) and receive a final payment.
Your decision may be selected to determine which system is implemented for these workers.
Therefore, please take this decision seriously - it might matter a lot for real people.
In this study there are other people who make the same decision as you. 1 in 30 respondents is selected at random to determine final payments for each set of 12 workers. If you are selected, your decision will be implemented for these 12 workers. Whether you are selected does not depend on your choice.

**Please make your choice now.**
*[System A and System B figures, see Figure B4.]*
Remember: both systems pay the same amount to each compensated worker and compensate 8 of the 12 workers.

◯ System A
◯ System B

*Post-choice questions*

REASONS

---

Can you briefly explain the reasons behind your choice?

*Answer:* open text box.

PERCEIVED BURDEN

---

Compared with System B (no form, automatic), how much more effort does System A (verification form of 7 minutes *[T2: 2 minutes]* required) require from workers to receive the compensation? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "No extra effort" and 10 means "Far more effort".

*Answer scale:* 0 (No extra effort) … 10 (Far more effort)

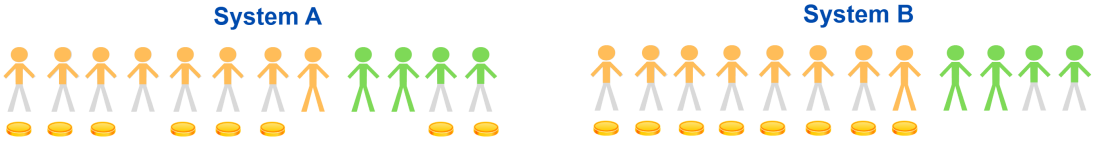
FAIRNESS OF THE DISTRIBUTION

---

Which system's distribution of the compensation is fairer?
Base your answer only on who receives the compensation and who does not, and ignore all other properties of the two systems.
Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "System A's distribution is much fairer" and 10 means "System B's distribution is much fairer".
As a reminder, here is the distribution of the compensation under each system.




*[T1 and T2. In T3 the System A panel is replaced by:]*




*Answer scale:* 0 (System A's distribution is much fairer) … 10 (System B's distribution is much fairer); 5 (Neither is fairer)

FAIRNESS OF THE REASON FOR EXCLUSION (T3 ONLY)

---

Under both systems, a worker whose output is not fully registered can end up without the compensation:

- Under System A, because the form is unavailable to them.

- Under System B, because they are assigned to Green, and compensation goes only to workers assigned to Yellow.

In both cases the worker fills in no form and receives no compensation.
Ignoring how many workers this happens to under each system, is one reason for missing out more unfair than the other? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "missing out under System A is much more unfair" and 10 means "missing out under System B is much more unfair".

*Answer scale:* 0 (missing out under System A is much more unfair) ... 10 (missing out under System B is much more unfair); 5 (Neither is more unfair)

*Final questionnaire (all treatments)*

INTRODUCTION

---

We will ask you a few final questions about your views and background.

ATTITUDES

---

Below, there are 6 statements about various issues. Please indicate how much you agree or disagree with each of the following statements on a scale from 0 (strongly disagree) to 10 (strongly agree).

1. Government departments are generally able to run public services efficiently.
2. The rules and procedures that government departments follow usually serve a real purpose.
3. Government departments waste a lot of money through errors and mismanagement.
4. I have trust in the civil service and government departments.
5. Large redistribution hurts the economy.
6. The government should take measures to reduce differences in income levels.

TARGETING VERSUS SIMPLICITY

---

Benefits like Universal Credit, Child Benefit and disability benefits each have their own conditions and their own application process: people fill in forms and report information about themselves.
This is not accidental - more conditions and more checks mean support can be targeted more closely on those who need it most. But it also means more time spent filling in forms, more to report, and more that can go wrong: some people who are entitled to support never claim it because the process is difficult.

It is possible to make benefit systems simpler by replacing targeted schemes with more universal ones. This makes benefits easier to claim and receive, but the trade-off is that support no longer fits everyone's situation as closely, so some people get more than they need and others less.

*Overall, where do you stand on this trade-off?* Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "benefits should be universal and easier to claim" and 10 means "benefits should be targeted, even if harder to claim."

*Answer scale:* 0 (benefits should be universal and easier to claim) … 10 (benefits should be targeted, even if harder to claim)

### SIMPLIFICATION POLICIES

Below are two examples of policies that could be introduced in place of current benefits in order to simplify the system.

**Policy 1.** This policy pays money to people on low incomes, based on income data the government already holds. There is no application and nothing to report. Because it is based on income alone, it does not adjust for things such as rent or who you live with.

**Policy 2.** This policy pays every adult resident the same monthly amount, enough to cover basic living costs. It is paid automatically, with no application and nothing to report. Because everyone receives it, it also goes to people who do not need it, which makes it more expensive.

*How much would you support introducing Policy 1? How much would you support introducing Policy 2?* Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "keep the current system as it is" and 10 means "fully support this change".

*Answer scale:* 0 (keep the current system as it is) … 10 (fully support this change)

### FAIRNESS VIEWS, IDEOLOGY, AND TRUST

We will now ask you about what you think of a hypothetical scenario.

Mark and Ben did the same task. Mark earned more than Ben for two reasons: he chose to work longer, and he also got a random bonus that Ben didn't. If you could adjust their pay, what would be fairest?

- ◯ Make their final earnings equal.
- ◯ Remove the part of the gap caused by the random bonus, but let Mark keep what he earned by working longer.
- ◯ Leave their earnings as they are. Mark is entitled to what he ended up with.

In political matters, people talk of "the left" and "the right". How would you place your views on this scale, generally speaking? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "left", and 10 means "right".

*Answer scale:* 0 (Left) … 10 (Right)

Generally speaking, would you say that most people can be trusted, or that you can't be too careful in dealing with people?

*Answer scale:* 0 (You can't be too careful) … 10 (Most people can be trusted)

## BACKGROUND

*What is your age? [text box]*

*What is your gender?* Male; Female; Non-binary; Prefer not to say; Prefer to self-describe.

*What is your country of birth?* UK; Other.

*What is the highest educational level that you have completed?* Secondary school or lower; Post-secondary / vocational (e.g. BTEC, NVQ); A-levels or equivalent; Some university, no degree; Bachelor's degree; Postgraduate degree (Master's or equivalent); Doctoral degree (PhD or equivalent).

*What is your current employment status?* Full-time employee; Part-time employee; Self-employed or small business owner; Unemployed; Student; Not in the labour force (for example: retired, or full-time parent).

*What was your yearly household income in 2025 pounds before taxes and deductions? (Note: household income = total amount of money earned by every member of your household)* Under £15,000; £15,000–£29,999; £30,000–£44,999; £45,000–£59,999; £60,000–£79,999; £80,000–£99,999; £100,000 or more.

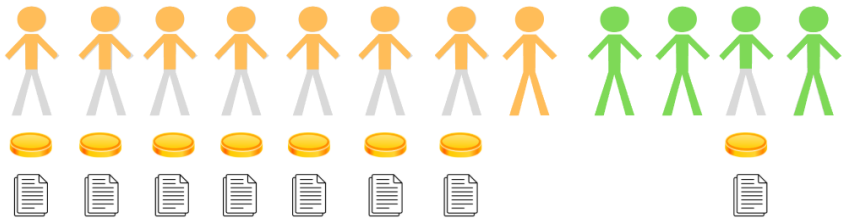
*Which of the following benefits have you ever received? (select all that apply)* Universal Credit or legacy means-tested benefits (Housing Benefit, Income Support, Tax Credits, Jobseeker's Allowance); Disability or health-related benefits; Child Benefit or Child Tax Credit; Carer's Allowance; Council Tax Reduction; Other; I have never received any welfare benefits or government financial support.

## END

Thank you for taking part in this study. Please click the button below to be redirected back to Prolific and register your submission.

**Figure B1.** Illustration of the two systems, T1

## System A



| Workers | Total Time | Paid |
|---|---|---|
| output not fully registered | 22 min (15 task + 7 form) | task earnings + compensation |
| output fully registered | 15 min | task earnings |

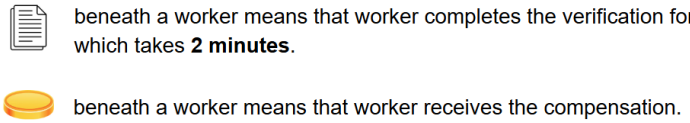
## System B



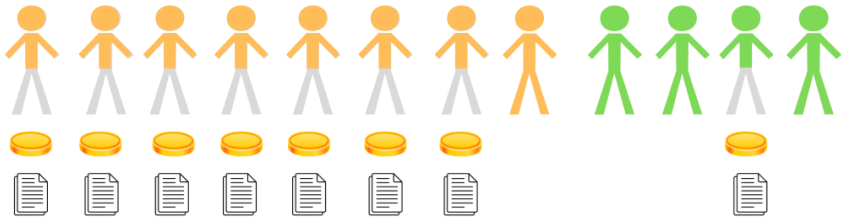
| Workers | Total Time | Paid |
|---|---|---|
| Yellow workers | 15min | task earnings + compensation |
| Green workers | 15 min | task earnings |

*Notes.* Screen shown to spectators in T1, below the "Remember" bullets. A coin beneath a worker means the worker receives the compensation; a sheet means the worker completes the verification form (legend on the previous screen).

**Figure B2.** Illustration of the two systems, T2




**System A**



| Workers | Total Time | Paid |
|---|---|---|
| output not fully registered | 17 min (15 task + 2 form) | task earnings + compensation |
| output fully registered | 15 min | task earnings |

**System B**



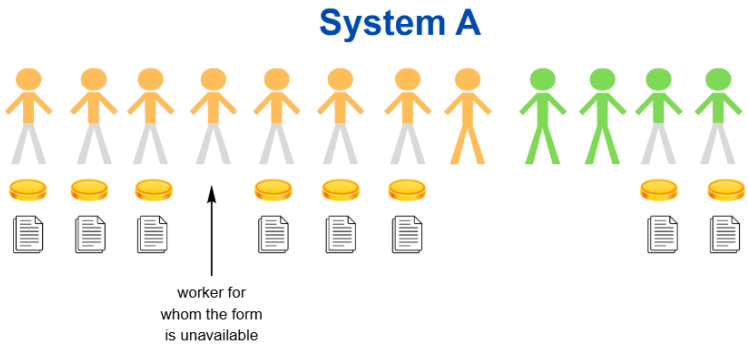
| Workers | Total Time | Paid |
|---|---|---|
| Yellow workers | 15min | task earnings + compensation |
| Green workers | 15 min | task earnings |

*Notes.* T2 differs from T1 only in the length of the form (2 instead of 7 minutes). The top panel is the legend shown on the previous screen in T2; the other panels are the illustration screen.

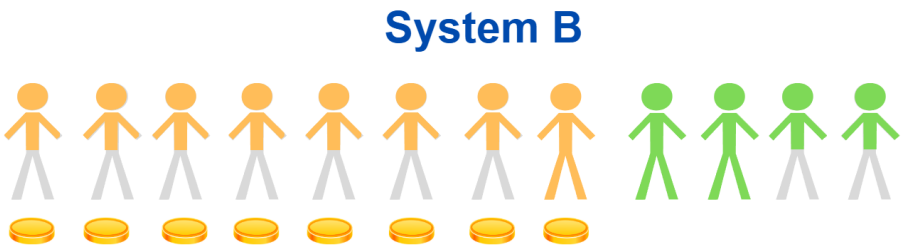
**Figure B3.** The 12 workers and illustration of the two systems, T3



(a) The 12 workers




| Workers | | Total Time | Paid |
|---|---|---|---|
| output not fully registered | form available | 22 min (15 task + 7 form) | task earnings + compensation |
| | form unavailable | 15 min | task earnings |
| output fully registered | | 15 min | task earnings |

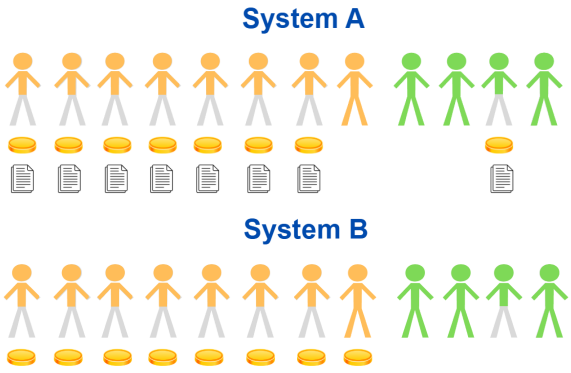



| Workers | Total Time | Paid |
|---|---|---|
| Yellow workers | 15min | task earnings + compensation |
| Green workers | 15 min | task earnings |

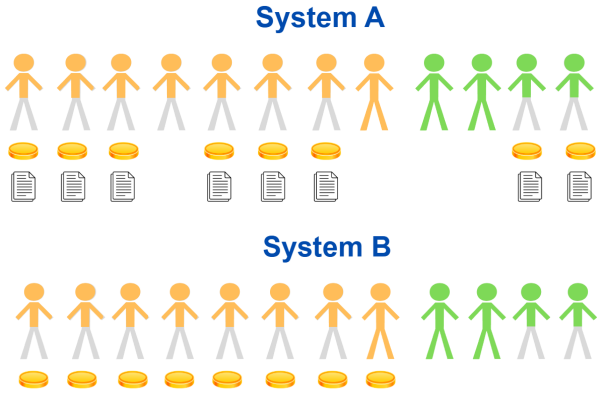
(b) Illustration of the two systems

*Notes.* In T3 two of the four Green workers have output that is not fully registered, and the form is unavailable to one Yellow worker whose output is not fully registered (marked by the arrow). System A therefore still compensates 8 workers (6 Yellow, 2 Green). The legend is the same as in T1 (7 minutes).

**Figure B4.** Figures on the quiz and choice screens




(a) T1 and T2




(b) T3

*Notes.* The figures were shown one above the other, System A first.

## B.2. Survey experiment

The survey experiment was programmed in Qualtrics and fielded in Dutch. The text below is our English translation; Dutch names of schemes are given in parentheses where useful. Respondents were randomly assigned to the topic control (C0), the elicitation control (C1), or the treatment (T). All questions on a 0–10 scale were displayed as eleven radio buttons with labelled endpoints. Several screens could not be skipped for a few seconds: the continue button appeared only after the time indicated in brackets.

*Consent and background*

WELCOME AND CONSENT

---

Welcome! Thank you for taking part in this study. This study is carried out by researchers at the University of Amsterdam. We use all the data we collect for research purposes only. Completing the survey takes about 15 minutes.
Your answers remain anonymous. The data may be published in aggregate form in scientific articles or presentations. Participation is voluntary. You can stop at any time.
We study how real people think and feel. The value of this study therefore depends on the answers truly being your own. Please do not use AI tools to write your answers or to help write them.
Please indicate below that you have read and understood this consent form, and that you take part in this study.

◯ I take part in this study and I have read the consent form.
◯ I do not want to take part in this study. *[ends the survey]*

BACKGROUND

---

*What is your age? [text box]*
*What is your gender?* Man; Woman; Non-binary; I prefer not to say; Other, namely:

_____

*What is the highest level of education you have completed with a diploma?* Primary education; Vmbo or mbo level 1; Havo or vwo; Mbo level 2, 3, or 4; Hbo; Wo; Other / I don't know.

INTRODUCTION TO THE STUDY

---

In this study we are interested in your opinion on and experiences with social security: the system of benefits and allowances (*uitkeringen en toeslagen*).

We ask what you think of this system and how satisfied you are with it. Please read each question carefully and give your honest opinion.
The results of this study may be shared with policymakers.

*Views on the welfare state (all arms, before randomisation)*

TOP OF MIND

---

In your view, what goes well in social security, and what goes less well? Please answer in one or two sentences.

*Answer:* open text box.

BIGGEST PROBLEMS

---

In your view, what are the biggest problems with social security in the Netherlands?
**Choose exactly 2.**

- ☐ The rules and paperwork are too complicated.
- ☐ Work does not pay, because people lose benefits and allowances when their income rises.
- ☐ There are too many different benefits and allowances, and too many agencies that administer them.
- ☐ Benefits and allowances are too high.
- ☐ Fraud and abuse.
- ☐ Benefits and allowances are too low for some people who depend on them.
- ☐ Other: _____

*[The first six options were shown in random order; "Other" was always last.]*

SATISFACTION

---

All in all, how satisfied are you with how social security (benefits and allowances) works? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "very dissatisfied" and 10 means "very satisfied".

*Answer scale:* 0 (very dissatisfied) … 10 (very satisfied)

*Prior beliefs*

*[Random assignment to C0, C1, or T. C1 and T answer the five questions below, one per screen. C0 answers only the two filler questions (the last two).]*

INTRODUCTION

---

In this part we ask you to estimate a few facts about social security in the Netherlands. All these figures come from official studies of the past few years. For each question, you give your answer by moving the slider. Please give your best estimate. Do not use other sources when answering the questions.

NON-TAKE-UP (C1, T)

---

Social assistance (*bijstand*) is a benefit for people who have too little income or wealth to make ends meet on their own. Someone is entitled to social assistance if they meet all the conditions, such as a low income and little wealth.
Out of every 100 people who are entitled to social assistance (who therefore meet all the conditions), how many do you think actually receive social assistance?

*Answer:* slider from 0 to 100 (steps of 1; current value shown).

UNDERSTANDING THE RULES (C1, T)

---

In a recent study, allowance recipients were asked which assets (savings and possessions) they must report for their allowance.
Out of every 100 people with an allowance, how many do you think answered the question correctly? This question is about people with healthcare allowance, rent allowance, or child-related budget (*zorgtoeslag, huurtoeslag, kindgebonden budget*).

*Answer:* slider from 0 to 100 (steps of 1; current value shown).

CORRECTIONS (C1, T)

---

Allowances are paid out during the year based on an estimate of income. If income turns out to be higher or lower than the estimate, people have to pay money back or receive extra money.
Out of every 100 households with rent allowance, how many do you think had to pay money back or received extra money at the end of the year, in a recent year?

*Answer:* slider from 0 to 100 (steps of 1; current value shown).

FILLER: AGE OF RECIPIENTS (ALL ARMS)

---

The healthcare allowance is a contribution to the cost of health insurance.
Out of every 100 people who receive healthcare allowance, how many do you think are aged 65 or older?

*Answer:* slider from 0 to 100 (steps of 1; current value shown).

FILLER: GENEROSITY (ALL ARMS)

---

Out of every 100 adults in the Netherlands, how many do you think receive some form of benefit or allowance, including pensions and child benefit?

*Answer:* slider from 0 to 100 (steps of 1; current value shown).

*Information: placebo (C0 and C1)*

INTRODUCTION

---

We will now show you a few facts about the history and organisation of social security in the Netherlands. For each topic you will see a year or a number, with a short explanation.
Each screen stays up for a few seconds so that you have time to read it calmly; after that, the button to continue appears.

PLACEBO 1 OF 4 *[8 seconds]*

---

**The AOW**
The year in which the General Old Age Pensions Act (AOW) was introduced: **1957**
The AOW is the state basic pension: everyone who reaches the AOW age receives the AOW. The AOW replaced the Emergency Act on Old Age Provision of 1947, a temporary scheme for older people. Under that emergency act, the number of benefits rose from 250 thousand in 1947 to 369 thousand in 1956.
Since 1980, the level of the AOW has been linked to the minimum wage: a single person receives 70 percent of the net minimum wage per month, married (and cohabiting) people 50 percent.

PLACEBO 2 OF 4 *[8 seconds]*

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**The SVB**
The year in which the SVB, which pays out the AOW, was founded: **1901**
The Social Insurance Bank (SVB) pays out the AOW. When it was founded in 1901, the organisation was called the Rijksverzekeringsbank; at the time it was the first agency administering social insurance in the Netherlands. The name has changed a few times since then. Today the SVB administers several schemes, including the AOW and child benefit.

PLACEBO 3 OF 4 *[8 seconds]*

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**Unemployment insurance**

The year in which unemployment insurance (WW) was introduced: **1952**

The Unemployment Insurance Act (WW) was passed in 1949 and came into force in 1952. It gives employees who lose their job a temporary income while they look for new work. The WW is administered by the UWV, which assesses the application and pays out the benefit.

PLACEBO 4 OF 4 *[8 seconds]*

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**Child benefit**

The year since which child benefit has been granted: **1941**

Child benefit is a contribution to the cost of raising children and has been granted since 1941. In 1962 the scheme was brought under the General Child Benefit Act (AKW). The Social Insurance Bank (SVB) pays out child benefit.

*Information: correction (T only)*

INTRODUCTION

---

We will now show you a few of your earlier estimates, next to the figures from official research. This way you can see whether your estimate was correct.

Each screen stays up for a few seconds so that you have time to read it calmly; after that, the button to continue appears.

*[Three correction screens follow, in the order below. "[your estimate]" was filled in with the respondent's own slider answer. The number in the "In reality" line was shown large and in red. Below it, a pictogram of 100 people showed the true number in red, and the explanatory text was set off by a red vertical bar.]*

CORRECTION 1 OF 3 *[10 seconds]*

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**Unclear rules**

*Your answer*

Out of every 100 people with an allowance, **[your estimate]** could correctly answer a question about which assets they must report for their allowance.

*In reality*

Out of every 100 people with an allowance, **26** could correctly answer a question about which assets they must report for their allowance. (SEO Amsterdam Economics)



The rules for allowances and benefits are often complicated. Every year, **about 50,000 people pay a commercial agency to fill in their application**. Many of those applications contain errors. This is not only the case for allowances: 40 out of 100 people on social assistance find the rules that apply to them **hard to understand**.

CORRECTION 2 OF 3 *[10 seconds]*

---

**Unexpected repayments**

*Your answer*

Out of every 100 households with rent allowance, **[your estimate]** have to pay money back or receive extra money at the end of the year.

*In reality*

Out of every 100 households with rent allowance, 68 have to pay money back or receive extra money at the end of the year. (CPB Netherlands Bureau for Economic Policy Analysis)



The Benefits Agency (*Dienst Toeslagen*) names the complexity of the allowance system as an important cause of this. For example, many people find it hard to estimate their annual income in advance. The number of households that get into debt because they have to pay back allowances has risen sharply in recent years.

CORRECTION 3 OF 3 *[12 seconds]*

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**Missing out on support**

*Your answer*

Out of every 100 people who are entitled to social assistance, **[your estimate]** actually receive social assistance.

*In reality*

Out of every 100 people who are entitled to social assistance, **65** actually receive social assistance. (Inspectorate of the Ministry of Social Affairs and Employment, Inspectie SZW)



So about 35 out of 100 people who are entitled to social assistance do not receive it. This is not only the case for social assistance: in 2021, €1 billion in allowances went unclaimed. Many people do not apply for support because they are afraid that they will have to pay money back later, or because they find the procedure too complicated. Because there are many different benefits, allowances, and agencies, some people do not always know what they are entitled to. Research shows that half of the people with a Wajong benefit do not know that they can get extra support if their income is too low to make ends meet.

*Posterior beliefs (all arms)*

IMPORTANCE

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How important do you think the role of social security is in Dutch society? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "not important at all" and 10 means "very important".

*Answer scale:* 0 (not important at all) … 10 (very important)

ATTENTION TO THE TOPIC

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How much attention do you usually pay to news or discussions about benefits and allowances? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "no attention at all" and 10 means "a great deal of attention".

*Answer scale:* 0 (no attention at all) … 10 (a great deal of attention)

HARM OF COMPLEXITY

---

Social security in the Netherlands consists of many separate schemes, each with its own rules, its own conditions, and its own application procedure.

All in all, do you think these features of the system make things better or worse for the people who are entitled to support? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "much worse", 5 "no difference", and 10 means "much better".

*Answer scale:* 0 (much worse) … 10 (much better); 5 (no difference)

ATTENTION CHECK

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People differ in how attentively they fill in a questionnaire. This is a check question: we want to know whether you read the questions attentively. Choose 7.
Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "not at all" and 10 means "very much".

*Answer scale:* 0 (not at all) … 10 (very much)

NUMERIC POSTERIOR (C1 AND T ONLY)

---

Out of every 100 people who receive healthcare allowance, how many do you think had to pay money back or received extra money at the end of the year?

*Answer:* slider from 0 to 100 (steps of 1; current value shown).

*Policy outcomes (all arms)*

INTRODUCTION

---

We will now ask what you think of various proposals that are currently being discussed. Before we ask your opinion on a proposal, we first give some background information about it. Each screen stays up for a few seconds so that you have time to read it calmly; after that, the button to continue appears.
There are no right or wrong answers. We are interested in your own opinion!

SOCIAL MINIMUM *[3 seconds]*

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The social minimum is the lowest income that the government guarantees to people who cannot support themselves. For a single adult with no other income, this is social assistance: about 70% of the net minimum wage.
To what extent are you for or against raising the social minimum? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "completely against" and 10 means "completely in favour".

*Answer scale:* 0 (completely against) … 10 (completely in favour)

HEALTH INSURANCE DEDUCTIBLE *[3 seconds]*

In Dutch health insurance, people pay the first €385 of healthcare costs per year themselves: the deductible (*eigen risico*).
To what extent are you for or against abolishing the €385 deductible? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "completely against" and 10 means "completely in favour".

*Answer scale:* 0 (completely against) … 10 (completely in favour)

POLICY 1: A SIMPLER SYSTEM *[5 seconds]*

Proposals have been made to make the system of benefits and allowances simpler. For example, the many separate benefits and allowances could be replaced by a smaller number of more general schemes. There are also other proposals.
As a result, the rules and conditions are clearer and simpler, so that people have more grip on the system. It is also easier to apply for support.
But support fits each person's situation less well. Some people get a bit more than they need and others a bit less.
Total spending on support stays about the same, and so do taxes. It remains just as hard as now to get support without being entitled to it.
Would you, in general, support such a change? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "keep the current system as it is" and 10 means "fully in favour of this change".

*Answer scale:* 0 (keep the current system as it is) … 10 (fully in favour of this change)

POLICY 2: A SINGLE BASIC ALLOWANCE *[7 seconds]*

**A proposal**
All allowances disappear, except the childcare allowance. Instead, every household in the Netherlands receives a single basic allowance (*basistoeslag*), paid out every month. Other benefits, such as social assistance, continue to exist.
How much a household receives depends on:

- the number of adults (one or two);
- the number of children;
- the ages of everyone in the household.

People can more easily get the support they are entitled to. Applying is simple and needs to be done only once: after that, people only have to check a few details.
The basic allowance stays the same every month and is not based on an estimate of income, so no money has to be paid back at the end of the year.

However, the basic allowance does not take into account things such as rent or healthcare costs, and is therefore less well tailored to individual situations.
This proposal is financed by abolishing tax credits and deductions, and the current allowances. It remains just as hard as now to get support without being entitled to it.
Would you, in general, support such a change? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "keep the current system as it is" and 10 means "fully in favour of this change".

*Answer scale:* 0 (keep the current system as it is) … 10 (fully in favour of this change)

POLICY 3: MILDER CONSEQUENCES OF MISTAKES *[5 seconds]*

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**A proposal**
At present, a mistake (for example, not reporting a change on time) can lead to a recovery of payments or a fine. In this proposal all schemes continue to exist, but the consequences of a mistake become milder.
Total spending on support stays about the same, and so do taxes. It remains just as hard as now to get support without being entitled to it.
Would you, in general, support such a change? Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "keep the current system as it is" and 10 means "fully in favour of this change".

*Answer scale:* 0 (keep the current system as it is) … 10 (fully in favour of this change)

*Final questions (all arms)*

BACKGROUND

---

*What is your current employment situation?* Employee, full-time; Employee, part-time; Self-employed (freelancer or business owner); Unemployed or looking for work; Unable to work (because of illness or a disability); Student or pupil; Retired; Caring for the family or household; Other, namely: _____
*Have you ever received a benefit, allowance, or other financial support from the government? Do not count the AOW or your employer pension.* Yes; No; I don't know.
*Which of the schemes below have you ever received? Several answers possible. [only if "Yes"]*
Healthcare allowance (*zorgtoeslag*); rent allowance (*huurtoeslag*); childcare allowance (*kinderopvangtoeslag*); child-related budget (*kindgebonden budget*); social assistance (*bijstand*); IOAW or IOAZ; social assistance for the self-employed (Bbz); WW (unemployment benefit); WGA; IVA; WAO; Wajong; Sickness Benefits Act (*Ziektewet*); child benefit (AKW); something else, namely: _____

*What was the net annual income of your household in 2025? Count all income of all household members: wages, benefits, allowances, pension, and other income, after taxes and deductions.* Less than €15,000; €15,000–24,999; €25,000–39,999; €40,000–54,999; €55,000–74,999; €75,000 or more; I don't know or prefer not to say.
*How much trust do you personally have in the government and public institutions in the Netherlands?* Please answer on the following scale, where 0 means "no trust at all" and 10 means "complete trust".
*In politics, people often talk about "left" and "right". Where would you place yourself on the scale below, where 0 means left and 10 means right?*

PURPOSE OF THE STUDY

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What do you think is the research question of this study? What do the researchers want to know?

*Answer:* open text box.

FEELING STEERED

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Did you feel that any part of the questionnaire steered you towards a particular answer? If so, which part?

*Answer:* open text box.

REASONS

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You have just seen a few proposals to make the system of benefits and allowances simpler. What are, for you, the most important arguments for or against them?
What is, for you personally, the most important reason for your opinion? Why are you yourself for or against?

*Answer:* open text box.

*Comprehension questions (T only)*

COMPREHENSION

---

Earlier in this study you had to estimate a few figures. After that, you saw the real figures. According to those real figures, was the system better or worse than you had thought? (0 = much worse than I thought, 5 = as I thought, 10 = much better than I thought)

*Answer scale:* 0 (much worse than I thought) … 10 (much better than I thought); 5 (as I thought)

Which statement best fits the information you saw earlier in this study?

◯ Most people get the support they are entitled to without much effort.
◯ For many people the system is so complicated that they make mistakes or miss out on support.
◯ Fraud and abuse are the biggest problems in the system.
◯ I don't remember.

Earlier in this study you saw how many out of 100 households with rent allowance had to pay money back or received extra money at the end of the year. Do you remember whether that was more or less than 50 out of 100?

◯ More than 50 out of 100
◯ Less than 50 out of 100
◯ I don't remember

## C. Derivations for the Conceptual Framework

This appendix derives the welfare difference between the two systems, $\Delta^t$, stated in Section 3.1. The notation is as in Section 3: a worker earns $y_L$ if their output was not fully registered and $y_H > y_L$ if it was, and consumption is $c_i = y_i + b_i$.

*Group composition.* Let $d_i = 1$ if worker $i$'s output was not fully registered and $d_i = 0$ otherwise, and let $k_i \in \{Y, G\}$ be the worker's colour. Let $n_{k,d}$ be the number of workers of colour $k$ with $d_i = d$, and $n_d \equiv n_{Y,d} + n_{G,d}$. In the experiment,

| | $n_{Y,1}$ | $n_{Y,0}$ | $n_{G,1}$ | $n_{G,0}$ | $n_1$ | $n_0$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T1, T2 | 7 | 1 | 1 | 3 | 8 | 4 |
| T3 | 7 | 1 | 2 | 2 | 9 | 3 |

*Welfare under each system.* The Simple system pays $b$ to every Yellow worker and nothing to Green workers, and no worker fills in the form:

$$\begin{aligned} W^S = n_{Y,1}\big[u(y_L + b) - v(e_T)\big] + n_{Y,0}\big[u(y_H + b) - v(e_T)\big] \\ + n_{G,1}\big[u(y_L) - v(e_T)\big] + n_{G,0}\big[u(y_H) - v(e_T)\big]. \end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

The Complex system pays $b$ only to workers whose output was not fully registered, who bear the additional effort $e_V$. Of the $n_1$ such workers, $n_V$ complete the form and $n_X = n_1 - n_V$ cannot; they are not compensated and exert only $e_T$:

$$W^C = n_V\big[u(y_L + b) - v(e_T + e_V)\big] + n_X\big[u(y_L) - v(e_T)\big] + n_0\big[u(y_H) - v(e_T)\big]. \tag{5}$$

In T1 and T2, $n_X = 0$; in T3, $n_X = 1$. Because both systems compensate eight workers, $n_V = 8$ in every treatment.

*T1 and T2.* Using $n_V = n_{Y,1} + n_{G,1}$ and $n_0 = n_{Y,0} + n_{G,0}$, the consumption terms of the Yellow workers whose output was not fully registered and all terms of the Green workers whose output was fully registered cancel, and

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta^t &= n_{Y,0}\big[u(y_H + b) - u(y_H)\big] - n_{G,1}\big[u(y_L + b) - u(y_L)\big] + n_V\big[v(e_T + e_V^t) - v(e_T)\big] \\ &= 8B^t - N, \qquad t \in \{T1, T2\},\end{aligned} \tag{6}$$

since $n_{Y,0} = n_{G,1} = 1$. The targeting term is the same in both treatments, so

$$\Delta^{T1} - \Delta^{T2} = 8\big[v(e_T + e_V^{T1}) - v(e_T + e_V^{T2})\big] > 0, \tag{7}$$

because $v$ is increasing and $e_V^{T1} > e_V^{T2}$. This gives Prediction 1.

*T3.* In T3, $n_{G,1} = 2$ and $n_X = 1$, so $n_V = 8$ as in T1:

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta^{T3} &= n_{Y,0}\big[u(y_H + b) - u(y_H)\big] - \big(n_{G,1} - n_X\big)\big[u(y_L + b) - u(y_L)\big] + n_V\big[v(e_T + e_V^{T1}) - v(e_T)\big] \\ &= 8B^{T1} - N = \Delta^{T1}.\end{aligned} \tag{8}$$

The excluded worker offsets the second Green worker whose output was not fully registered, which gives Prediction 2.

## D. Rank-Dependent Welfare Functions

This appendix derives how support for the Complex system changes from T1 to T3 for a spectator with a rank-dependent welfare function,

$$W = \sum_{r=1}^{12} a_r\, U_{(r)}, \qquad a_1 \geq a_2 \geq \cdots \geq a_{12} > 0, \tag{9}$$

where $U_{(r)}$ is the $r$-th lowest utility in the group of twelve workers. The utilitarian welfare function is the case in which all weights are equal, and the Rawlsian welfare function is the limit in which all weight is on $a_1$. Sen's welfare function and the generalised Gini welfare functions lie in between.

*Utility levels.* Under the two systems, each worker has one of five utility levels:

| | Output, compensation | Utility |
|---|---|---|
| $L$ | not fully registered, not compensated | $u(y_L) - v(e_T)$ |
| $H$ | fully registered, not compensated | $u(y_H) - v(e_T)$ |
| $P$ | not fully registered, compensated, no form (Simple) | $u(y_L + b) - v(e_T)$ |
| $R$ | fully registered, compensated, no form (Simple) | $u(y_H + b) - v(e_T)$ |
| $F$ | not fully registered, compensated after the form (Complex) | $u(y_L + b) - v(e_T + e_V)$ |

Let $G \equiv u(y_L + b) - u(y_L)$ be the utility gain from the compensation for a worker whose output was not fully registered, and $B \equiv B^{T1}$ the burden of the form. Suppose the spectator believes, as the instructions state, that the compensation offsets the lost earnings, $y_L + b = y_H$, and that the compensation outweighs the burden of the form, $B < G$. Then $P = H$, $H - L = G$, $H - F = B$ and $F - L = G - B > 0$, so that

$$L < F < H = P < R. \tag{10}$$

*Ranks.* Sorting each group from the worst-off to the best-off worker gives:

| | Ranks, from worst-off to best-off | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Simple, T1 | $L$: 1 | $H$ or $P$: 2–11 | $R$: 12 |
| Simple, T3 | $L$: 1–2 | $H$ or $P$: 3–11 | $R$: 12 |
| Complex, T1 | $F$: 1–8 | $H$: 9–12 | |
| Complex, T3 | $L$: 1 | $F$: 2–9 | $H$: 10–12 |

Collecting the weights of the ranks that each utility level occupies,

$$\begin{aligned} W^S_{T1} &= a_1 L + (a_2 + \cdots + a_{11})\, H + a_{12} R, \\ W^S_{T3} &= (a_1 + a_2)\, L + (a_3 + \cdots + a_{11})\, H + a_{12} R, \\ W^C_{T1} &= (a_1 + \cdots + a_8)\, F + (a_9 + \cdots + a_{12})\, H, \\ W^C_{T3} &= a_1 L + (a_2 + \cdots + a_9)\, F + (a_{10} + \cdots + a_{12})\, H. \end{aligned} \tag{11}$$

*Change from T1 to T3.* Under the Simple system, the additional uncompensated worker becomes the second worst-off, and all other workers keep their rank and utility:

$$W^S_{T3} - W^S_{T1} = -a_2(H - L) = -a_2\, G. \tag{12}$$

Under the Complex system, the excluded worker becomes the worst-off, and each of the eight workers who complete the form moves up one rank, so that one of them replaces a

worker whose output was fully registered at rank 9:

$$W^C_{T3} - W^C_{T1} = a_1 L + (a_9 - a_1)\, F - a_9 H = -a_1 \big[G - B\big] - a_9\, B. \tag{13}$$

Writing $G = \big[G - B\big] + B$ in the first expression and taking the difference,

$$\Delta^{T3} - \Delta^{T1} = (a_1 - a_2)\big[G - B\big] - (a_2 - a_9)\, B. \tag{14}$$

The first term is non-negative and works against the Complex system: the excluded worker is the worst-off under the Complex system but only the second worst-off under the Simple system. The second term is non-negative and works in its favour: the burden of the form now falls on a worker at rank 9 rather than on one at rank 2. Support for the Complex system falls if the first term is larger, that is, if the weights decline steeply at the bottom of the distribution relative to the burden of the form, and rises if the second term is larger.

The utilitarian case, with all weights equal, gives $\Delta^{T3} - \Delta^{T1} = 0$, as in Prediction 2. The Rawlsian case, with all weight on $a_1$, gives $a_1\big[G - B\big] > 0$. Sen's welfare function, average welfare multiplied by one minus the Gini coefficient, gives the weights $a_r = 2(12 - r) + 1$, that is, $23, 21, 19, \ldots, 3, 1$ (up to a positive factor, which does not affect the choice). Consecutive weights differ by 2, so $a_1 - a_2 = 2$, $a_2 - a_9 = 14$, and

$$\Delta^{T3} - \Delta^{T1} = 2\, G - 16B, \tag{15}$$

which is positive if and only if $G > 8B$.

*If the burden outweighs the compensation.* If $B > G$, then $F < L$: the workers who complete the form are the eight worst-off under the Complex system in both treatments, and the excluded worker enters at rank 9. Then $W^C_{T3} - W^C_{T1} = -a_9\, G$, while the change under the Simple system is unchanged, so

$$\Delta^{T3} - \Delta^{T1} = -(a_2 - a_9)\, G \leq 0, \tag{16}$$

and support for the Complex system weakly rises.